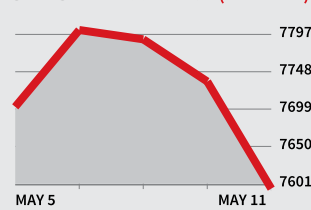


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 76015.28 (-1312.91)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23815.85	-360.30
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.56	-0.37
US Dollar (in ₹)	95.31	+0.83
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	149760.00	-713
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	256200.00	+600

STRATEGY FOR INDIA INC.

Shaktikanta Das, Principal Secretary to Prime Minister, proposes 7 key points for India Inc to mitigate global volatility **p2**



UNDER PRESSURE.

The rupee hit an all-time low of 95.31/\$ on continued US-Iran face-off leading to a rise in crude oil prices **p3**

QUICKLY.

UNCERTAIN TIMES

Nifty slips below 24,000, FPIs continue to pull out



Mumbai: Equities tumbled on Monday after the collapse of US-Iran peace talks sent crude oil soaring past \$100 a barrel, rattling investor sentiment from the opening bell. Aggressive selling by foreign portfolio investors, whose outflows have crossed ₹2 lakh crore so far in 2026, added to the pressure. The Nifty 50 fell 360.30 points to 23,815.85, its lowest level in three weeks. Sensex declined 1,312.91 points to 76,015.28. **p6**

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Modi repeats call for reducing imports amid global turmoil

TOUGH TIMES. PM says people have fulfilled their responsibility at times of war, crisis

Our Bureau
New Delhi

A day after asking people to reduce consumption of petrol, diesel and other commodities, Prime Minister Narendra Modi again issued an appeal to citizens to support the government's efforts to combat global economic disruptions by consciously reducing import dependence and avoiding activities that involve excessive foreign exchange outflow.

CONSERVE FOREX

Speaking in Vadodara, the PM drew parallels with previous national crises and wars. "Whenever India faced a war or any major crisis, citizens fulfilled their responsibility on the government's appeal. We need to do the same now. We must make all efforts to reduce imports and avoid personal activities that involve spending foreign currency," the PM said.

"India spends lakhs of crores of rupees in foreign exchange to import many products. The prices of imported goods are soaring and



MAKING A POINT. We must make all efforts to reduce imports and avoid personal activities that involve spending foreign currency, said Narendra Modi in Vadodara **ANI**

global supply chains have been severely disrupted. Just as every drop fills a pot, every small and big effort matters. We must reduce the use of products that come from abroad and avoid unnecessary dependence on imported goods in our daily lives."

ENOUGH OIL STOCKS

Simultaneously, the government also reiterated the PM's appeal while assuring that crude oil inventories remain stable and refineries are operating at optimum levels.

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh chaired the fifth meet-

ing of the Informal Group of Ministers to review the risks to energy supply chains and domestic availability of essential commodities in the wake of the West Asia conflict.

"I urge people to remain calm and avoid any kind of panic as the government is taking concrete steps to prevent shortages or disruptions in supply chains. PM Modi's appeal for collective participation of the people to help the country face global disruptions and challenges is going to be a significant step towards self-reliance and ensuring energy security," Singh

stated in a post on X.

Speaking at an inter-ministerial press briefing, Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary (Marketing and Oil Refinery), Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, outlined the official measures to ensure uninterrupted fuel supplies.

NO FUEL, LPG DRY-OUT

"...Our crude oil inventory remains well-maintained. Our refineries are operating at optimum levels. There are no instances of dry-outs at any retail outlet. Nor has any dry-out been reported at LPG distributorships. Adequate stocks of petrol and diesel are available, and LPG supplies for domestic cooking purposes are being maintained," Sharma said.

She noted that over the past three days, 1.26 crore LPG cylinders had been delivered to households against 1.14 crore bookings. She added that sales of commercial LPG have exceeded 17,000 tonnes while sales of auto LPG have also surpassed 762 tonnes.

Ample fertilizer stocks for kharif: Govt p10

Jewellers to approach PMO over Modi asking people to curb gold buy

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

Jewellers' associations across the country are planning to approach the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) over Prime Minister Narendra Modi's remarks urging consumers to go slow on gold jewellery purchases for one year to help reduce India's import bill amid rising global uncertainty.

Rajesh Rokde, Chairman, All India Gem and Jewellery Domestic Council, said the council is seeking an appointment with the PMO to discuss the issue in detail.

"Our objective is to present long-term solutions that can make India truly self-reliant by channelling idle household gold into the formal economy, rather than depending heavily on imports. This dialogue will be crucial in aligning industry practices with national priorities while safeguarding livelihoods and consumer trust," he said.

SHARP REACTIONS

PM Modi made the remarks at a rally in Secunderabad on Sunday, where he suggested measures to curb foreign exchange outgo, including reducing fuel consumption through public transport, opt-



ing for work from home and limiting foreign travel.

The comments triggered sharp reactions from jewellers, particularly in Lucknow, where traders called for a market shutdown. The Lucknow Mahanagar Sarafa Association observed a one-day shutdown on Monday, warning that the remarks could severely hurt artisans and traders during the crucial wedding season.

India's jewellery demand is already hovering near a 30-year low due to elevated gold prices and weak consumer sentiment. Industry estimates suggest that any slowdown in gold jewellery sales could affect more than one crore people employed in the sector.

C Vinod Hayagriv, MD, C Krishniah Chetty Group, said

structural reforms could help address the import issue more effectively.

ECONOMIC SAFEGUARD

"A simple structural reform permitting the sale of raw bullion only to GST-registered buyers can immediately reduce unnecessary imports, improve transparency and strengthen the organised jewellery ecosystem," he said. "This is not a short-term measure but a long-term economic safeguard that can benefit the country for years to come. India must encourage value-added consumption of gold rather than idle locker-based investments that do not support the broader economy," Hayagriv added.

Govt has no plan to raise import duties on gold and silver

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

India does not plan to increase duties on gold and silver imports despite concerns about rising import bills and dwindling foreign exchange reserves, a government official said on Monday.

Details p10

India Inc bats for hybrid model as PM suggests WFH to manage West Asia crisis

Sindhu Hariharan
Vallari Sanzgiri
Chennai/Mumbai

Even as the Prime Minister appealed to citizens and companies to consider working from home (WFH), India Inc said the current hybrid work model is helping balance business needs with managing the West Asia crisis. Employee groups, however, are calling for a clear government advisory on remote work.

While most companies contacted by *businessline* said they are assessing the PM's advisory and monitoring the geopolitical situation, they noted that the well-established hybrid model and recent energy-saving measures are helping them navigate the crisis.

IT industry body Nasscom said on Monday, "The technology industry in India continues to operate on well-established hybrid work models, with organisations calibrating work-from-home and in-office arrangements based on role requirements and customer needs."

An executive at a large technology GCC in Chennai said the company is assessing the advisory but had already taken steps over the last two months to ration energy use in facility management. "The hybrid model will be continued as has been the practice," the person said.

Zoho Co-founder Sridhar Vembu told *businessline* that almost all its employees had returned to office in recent months, but the company will now look at two days a week of WFH, following the

PM's appeal. However, IT unions have urged the government to issue clear directions to companies on WFH.

UNIONS SEEK CLARITY

"Such an advisory would significantly contribute towards reducing fuel consumption, traffic congestion, environmental burden, and unnecessary travel while preserving uninterrupted economic activity through digital means," Harpreet Singh Saluja, President, Nascent Information Technology Employees Senate (NITES), a over 7,000 member union, said in a letter to the Ministry of Labour.

Similarly, the Forum for IT Employees (FITE) urged the government to issue an official notification allowing WFH wherever possible.

Human Resource experts

said companies are now better prepared to implement flexible work at short notice, but are reluctant to fully return to remote work.

Aditya Mishra, CEO, CIEL HR Services, said a complete return to the Covid-era remote work culture is unlikely.

FLEXIBILITY FACTOR

Flexibility is no longer a temporary perk, but a strategic factor influencing hiring, employer branding, and long-term talent retention, said Sarbojit Mallick, Co-founder, Instahyre.

However, Neeti Sharma, CEO, Teamlease Digital, said while most companies have settled into a balanced 2/3-day office model, many young professionals still lack the physical and digital infrastructure needed for effective remote work.

Vizag port turns its operations into a visual treat

Berthing of ships, working of giant cranes can be enjoyed from waterfront promenade

G Naga Sridhar
Visakhapatnam

Imagine sipping coffee and snacking while watching ships glide in, tugboats manoeuvre giant vessels and towering cranes swing into action. Visakhapatnam is set to offer the public a real-time glimpse into maritime operations with the launch of the Port Promenade next week.

"Ports are often enigmatic spaces for the common man — restricted, industrial, and rarely seen up close — yet they evoke enduring curiosity. We will provide a rare opportunity to the general public to witness this from about 100 metres away," M Angamuthu, Chairperson, Visakhapatnam Port Authority (VPA), told *businessline*. The port handles around 2,500 ships annually, and



A night view of the Vizag Port promenade that will be open to the public next week

visitors can watch tugboats guide vessels to berths from the over 600-metre-long promenade overlooking the International Cruise Terminal.

Historically, ports have been viewed as restricted zones — vital to the economy, but detached from public life. The promenade project seeks to change that perception. Without compromising security, it allows citizens to engage

visually with the port, understand its scale, appreciate maritime activity and reconnect with an institution that shaped Visakhapatnam's growth.

MARITIME THEATRE

"Moving ships, cranes, docking sequences, container yards and cruise liners become part of the visual narrative. The promenade transforms maritime operations into a form of

urban theatre," Angamuthu said.

While port promenades are not new globally, VPA says the Vizag experience will stand apart. "This one coexists with an active port and is not a redeveloped waterfront," Angamuthu said.

Many waterfront promenades around the world have come up on abandoned docks, reclaimed industrial land or along beaches. In contrast, Visakhapatnam Port remains fully operational, with cargo ships moving continuously, berths active and logistics infrastructure functioning uninterrupted.

Vizag Port, officially opened to ocean traffic in 1933, recorded its highest-ever annual cargo throughput of 90.29 million tonnes in FY26, achieved in just 362 days. VPA is eyeing over 100 mt in FY27.

MF SIP inflows slow a tad in April on market volatility; too early to call it a trend, says AMFI

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

Inflows into mutual fund schemes through Systematic Investment Plans (SIPs) declined marginally last month to ₹31,115 crore from ₹32,087 crore in March on heightened volatility in equity markets.

The number of contributing SIP accounts also dipped a tad to 9.65 crore in April from 9.72 crore in March, while SIP assets rose to ₹16.85-lakh crore from ₹15.11-lakh crore despite sharp swings in the market and continued foreign portfolio investor outflows.

The number of discontinued SIP accounts stood at 51.21 lakh, marginally higher than the 50.71 lakh new SIP accounts opened in April.

'NOT A SLOWDOWN'

Venkat Chalasani, CEO, As-

sociation of Mutual Funds in India, said the higher number of SIP stoppages compared with new accounts opened could be due to SEBI norms mandating that a SIP account be classified as discontinued if instalments are stopped continuously for three months.

Moreover, the March inflow figure was an aberration as it included the last four days of February, which were market holidays, he said.

AMFI feels it is too early to conclude that the dip in SIP inflows marks a trend, though market volatility may have impacted investor sentiment.

Suranjana Borthakur, Head of Distribution and Strategic Alliances, Mirae Asset Investment Managers (India), said the slight moderation in SIP inflows should not be seen as a slowdown, especially after the previous month's elevated numbers due to

spillover inflows.

SIP inflows sustaining at around the ₹31,000-crore mark reflects the steady participation of retail investors in mutual funds, she added.

Equity mutual fund inflows also declined 5 per cent in April to ₹38,440 crore from ₹40,450 crore in March.

RESILIENT INVESTORS

A Balasubramanian, Managing Director and CEO, Aditya Birla Sun Life AMC, said continued investor participation in mutual funds despite volatile market conditions reflects the growing maturity and resilience of retail investors, who are increasingly preferring diversified allocation strategies.

This shift indicates a balanced approach to wealth creation, with investors focussing on asset allocation, stability and long-term

goal-based investing amid global uncertainties, he said.

Navneet Munot, MD and CEO, HDFC Asset Management Company, said equity flows have held up well, reflecting the growing maturity of the investor base and deepening awareness about the merits of systematic investing.

While markets will always contend with geopolitical developments, data suggest that long-term financial goals are increasingly guiding investment decisions over short-term noise, he added.

GOLD & SILVER ETFs

Gold ETFs attracted investments of ₹3,040 crore in April compared with ₹2,265 crore in March, while outflows from silver ETFs moderated to ₹125 crore from ₹684 crore, as investors used the decline in prices to increase allocations.

QUICKLY.

Wingreen Farms acquires Safe Harvest, raises funds



New Delhi: Packaged food and beverage compnay, Wingreens has acquired Safe Harvest through a share-swap transaction. It has also secured a Series D funding round of around ₹120 crore (\$12.6 million). OUR BUREAU

As Bajaj group turns 100, PM lauds its contribution

Mumbai: The diversified Bajaj group, having interests in auto and financial services, turned 100 years old on Monday. Prime Minister Narendra Modi lauded the group's work. "Over the decades, the Bajaj Group has played an important role in nation-building by creating jobs, fostering innovation and supporting community development," he said in a congratulatory message. PM

Shaktikanta Das proposes 7 strategies for India Inc to mitigate global volatility

KEY ADVICE. Think boldly, innovate fearlessly and invest strategically in emerging opportunities, he said

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Indian industry must move beyond incremental progress to transformative action, said Principal Secretary-2 to Prime Minister, Shaktikanta Das, here on Monday. He also proposed seven strategies for India Inc to mitigate unprecedented volatility at global level. "This is the moment for enterprises to think boldly, innovate fearlessly and invest strategically in emerging opportunities. Indian industry must move beyond incremental progress to transformative action – creating global champions, building resilient supply chains, pioneering new technologies and solving national challenges at scale," Das said while addressing CII Annual Business Summit here. According to him, the road to India@2047 begins not in



Principal Secretary to Prime Minister Shaktikanta Das (right) being felicitated during the CII Annual Business Summit 2026

ambition alone, but in strategic action in the present. "The reforms and hard work of today will be the pillars of tomorrow's India – an India that is prosperous, inclusive and innovative. This approach, I feel, would enable India to consolidate its transformative journey from being an Incredible India to a Credible India – an India that inspires trust and confidence, both at home and

abroad," Das, the former governor of RBI, said.

TACKLING VOLATILITY Taking note of unprecedented volatility at global level, he suggested seven strategies for India Inc. First is that Indian businesses must embed resilience into their operating models by strengthening risk management, improving decision-making agility, and proact-

ively anticipating market, technological and other emerging developments in the world of business. "This would enable firms to absorb shocks, adapt quickly, and emerge stronger, turning uncertainty into opportunity," he said.

The second is about strengthening balance sheets. Third is related to building new supply chains. Fourth is about re-skilling the available manpower. Fifth suggests diversify into new markets. Sixth is to invest strategically for future readiness and for capitalising on new opportunities and seventh calls for increasing expenditure on research and development.

"These measures, I feel, can significantly enhance sustainability, competitiveness and long-term growth of Indian businesses and industry. This would enable us to not only weather global uncertainties, but emerge

stronger and more confident," he said.

Das said since over-dependence on a narrow set of markets or geographies increases vulnerability during global slowdowns, especially for exporters, Indian businesses should actively explore and engage with new export markets and leverage on India's growing economic and diplomatic footprint. "Market diversification would spread the risks, stabilise revenue streams and allow firms to tap into new growth corridors and demand patterns," he said. He said that India has made a sustained push towards reliance on alternative energy and investment in renewable energy has risen sharply, which will help mitigate the challenges posed by the war in West Asia. "India is better positioned today to confront extreme (energy) demand conditions head-on and emerge resilient," he said.

Electronics shipments, among top 3 India exports, will rise futher: Vaishnaw

Our Bureau
New Delhi



Minister for Electronics and Information Technology, Ashwini Vaishnaw ANI

Electronics exports emerged among the top three exported goods from India last year and it will grow more in the future, Ashwini Vaishnaw, Minister of Electronics and Information Technology, said here.

Speaking at the CII Annual Business Summit 2026, Vaishnaw said that until the last decade, diesel used to be India's single largest exported commodity, but the dynamics are changing now.

"Last financial year, smartphones was the largest exported commodity out of India, and electronics has become among the top three categories for exports. And, this is just the beginning. We also exported about ₹30,000-crore worth of electronic components to our neighbour, which again is a very big change," he said.

ELECTRONICS PARTS

For electronic components, there are 71 manufacturing facilities across India now, many of which are in advanced stage of construction, he informed.

"Many components will have 100 per cent of our domestic demand met. Many companies will become part of the global value-chain and start exporting to the world. And, I've been asking the manufacturers to focus a lot on what we say quality quality, 6 Sigma, lean manufacturing and design inputs to make sure that we can compete with the world over a very long term, not just for five-six years but build that base which will take us to the Vikshit Bharat," Vaishnaw added.

On semiconductor manufacturing, he said there are two factories already in commercial production, the third should start commercial production in July and the fourth should start in November or December.

"There is an opportunity for India to take the lead when the technology is chan-

ging. I hope, 22 months from now, we should have the first production of micro LED screens coming out our factories," Vaishnaw said.

RAILWAYS SECTOR

Highlighting the unprecedented scale of transformation in the Railways sector, Vaishnaw said railway capital expenditure has increased from around ₹66,000 crore a few years ago to nearly ₹2.72 lakh crore in the last financial year. He noted that the execution capability of the entire railway ecosystem has expanded simultaneously, reflecting a major cultural transformation in project implementation and delivery.

He said 49,000 km of railway tracks across the country have been electrified, which is more than the entire network of Germany, and 36,000 km of new tracks have been added, which is about six times the size of Switzerland in the Indian railway network.

The Minister also said that on many of these routes, travel time will be significantly reduced, and people will prefer trains to air travel. For instance, Bengaluru to Chennai travel time will be reduced to 78 minutes. Delhi to Varanasi will be 3 hours and 50 minutes, Delhi to Lucknow will be significantly lesser, just about two hours, he noted. "So nobody will fly. These sectors will be out for airlines. I am reminding right away for those who want to invest in airlines. These sectors will be 99 per cent dominated by railways."

India must build, power and own infra of the intelligence future: Adani

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Gautam Adani, on Monday, advocated for the development of artificial intelligence (AI) in India. "India must not rent the infrastructure of its intelligence future. India must build it. India must power it. India must own it on its own soil," Adani said while addressing a Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) Annual Business Summit here.

He said the intelligence age will not be built solely on servers, chips and algorithms. It will be built by electricians, technicians, operators, safety officers, cooling engineers, grid managers, data centre teams and millions of young Indians who will maintain the phys-

ical infrastructure behind the digital world. "Through the Adani Foundation, we have made a long-term commitment of ₹60,000 crore towards education, healthcare, skilling and community development. A growing share of this effort is being directed towards AI-integrated skilling," he said.

EMPOWER MILLIONS

Talking about building India's AI spine, he said the real measure of AI will not be how many jobs it replaces. The real measure will be how many Indians it empowers. Giving an example of his own journey, he said he has spent his life constructing things that did not yet exist, in places that were not yet ready. Ports where there were only marshlands. Power in places that knew

Semiconductors have become instruments of State-craft. Data is being treated as a national resource.

GAUTAM ADANI
Chairman, Adani Group



only darkness. An infrastructure that many saw as impossible.

"And if there is one lesson I have learned, it is this: The future does not arrive. It is built. So, let us build," Adani said.

He urged this to be built for the farmer who has always known his land, but never had the tools to fully read it. This needs to be built for the nurse who has always

had the instinct, but never had the instruments. This needs to be built for the teacher in a school without a library, who may soon have the world's knowledge in her hands. This needs to be built for the small manufacturer who has skill, but needs intelligence to compete globally.

"These are the people of Bharat that AI must be built to serve. The next freedom

struggle will not be fought only at our borders. It will be fought in our grids, our data centres, our factories, our classrooms, our laboratories and our minds. And this time, freedom will mean capability," he said, while explaining the capability to power, to compute and to dream for "ourselves". "It begins here. It begins now. And it begins with us," he concluded.

ENERGY, DIGITAL INFRA

Adani said on Monday that energy security and digital infrastructure would define geopolitical power in the coming decades, as he called on India to build sovereign capabilities across the AI value chain. He also said the assumptions underpinning decades of globalisation were being dismantled amid

rising geopolitical fragmentation. "The world that is emerging is not flat. It is fractured and contested," Adani said. "Semiconductors have become instruments of State-craft. Data is being treated as a national resource. Clouds are being weaponised. And AI is being built behind the protective walls of data centres."

Referring to recent geopolitical conflicts and attacks on infrastructure, Adani said: "Energy security and digital security are now the twin pillars of national power." "The country that controls its energy will power its industrial future. The country that controls its compute will power its intelligence future. And the country that controls both will shape the century ahead," he said.

Toyota Motor's new Maharashtra plant to attract ₹20,000-crore investments in several phases

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai



EXISTING UNITS. Toyota Kirloskar Motor currently operates two plants at Bidadi near Bengaluru with a combined installed capacity of 342,000 vehicles annually

Toyota Motor Corp. is expanding its manufacturing footprint in India with a new vehicle plant at Bidkin in Maharashtra's Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar district. The project is expected to attract investments of around ₹20,000 crore over multiple phases, a senior official in the State's Industries Department told *businessline*, although Toyota Kirloskar Motor did not disclose any investment figure in its announcement on Monday.

Toyota Kirloskar Motor said it will build a greenfield manufacturing facility at the Bidkin Industrial Area, with production scheduled to begin in the first half of 2029. The plant will have an initial capacity of one lakh vehicles

a year and employ about 2,800 people.

The company said the facility will be positioned to "steadily deliver vehicles not only to customers in India but also to customers in surrounding regions."

The project marks Toyota's first major greenfield manufacturing invest-

ment in India in more than a decade and its first production base outside Karnataka, where it currently operates two plants at Bidadi with a combined installed capacity of 342,000 vehicles annually. The Maharashtra facility will raise Toyota's installed capacity in India to about 442,000 vehicles a year in the first

phase, an increase of roughly 29 per cent.

FUTURE MODELS

Though Toyota has officially confirmed that the Bidkin plant's first product will be a new SUV, industry speculation suggests the facility could eventually become the production base for a broader family of utility vehicles positioned between the Urban Cruiser Hyryder and Fortuner, helping Toyota address a key gap in its India portfolio.

The plant's integrated manufacturing set-up, covering stamping, welding, painting and assembly, will give Toyota flexibility to build hybrid and conventional SUVs. Its export-oriented mandate also makes such products well suited for markets in West Asia and Africa.

India must move faster towards renewable energy, spend more within the country, says Sunil Mittal

Our Bureau
New Delhi



Sunil Bharti Mittal , Founder and Chairman, Bharti Enterprises

The crisis in West Asia is creating a tremendous pressure on economies globally and India is no different, Bharti Enterprises Founder and Chairman, Sunil Bharti Mittal, said on Monday, adding that India needs to move faster towards renewable energy and spend more within the country.

"We need to get away from this obsession of import of gold. We need to lower our energy costs. We need to move more faster towards renewable energy in our industry. And importantly, we need to vote with our feet within our country. Spend more here, put more capex here. My own company, Airtel, in 2024-25, spent about ₹31,000 crore in capex," Mitt-

tal said while addressing the CII Annual Business Summit 2026 here.

He said the investment will keep going up in the current year too.

"This is not the moment to shy away. This is the moment to invest, double down in our own country, because the underlying growth is there. This is a continent of

consumers, large, young population wanting more products and more services. And let's give them more from India, make in India, from India, serving India," he noted.

GROWTH OF 6-7%

He said though these are difficult times, India has been moving at a "fantastic speed", growing at 6-7 per cent year over year.

"Generally, things are looking very good. But there are situations that develop, which are beyond anybody's control...We can't escape the difficulties that the world is facing currently in economic terms. We need to play our part," Mittal said.

His reactions come a day after Prime Minister Narendra Modi called for measures by citizens to overcome the challenges emerging from

the war involving the US, Israel and Iran, to help the country in many ways, including judicious use of fuel and saving foreign exchange.

Mittal added that the Prime Minister's message was very profound and he would encourage most of the young budding businessmen, entrepreneurs to take responsibilities within CII because the government looks towards chambers, especially a chamber like CII, to work closely with them to guide their policy framework.

Meanwhile, Mittal was conferred with the CII President's Award for Lifetime Achievement, recognising his enduring leadership, contribution to India's economic progress, and commitment towards nation building.

PVR INOX back in black with 26% Q4 revenue growth

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi



PVR INOX posted a consolidated net profit of ₹186.4 crore in the March quarter compared to net loss of ₹125.3 crore in the corresponding quarter in the year-ago period. Revenue from operations was up 25.8 per cent to ₹1,547.3 crore. The average ticket price stood at ₹315, up 22 per cent and average food and beverages spend per head stood at ₹165, up 32 per cent.

Ajay Bijli, MD, PVR INOX, told *businessline* that the growth of Indian box office in FY26 reflected a strong structural demand for out-of-entertainment in India. "I have always been very bullish about the Indian market because of the sheer number and variety of movies across

languages and genres and the appetite for people to continue to go out remains very robust. FY26 has proven that people have not only come to the cinemas to watch blockbusters, but also mid-scale movies."

"We had some big hits like *Dhurandhar* and *Satyaara*, but we also had some sleeper hits as *Mahavatar Narsimha*, *Laalo Krishna* besides successful Hollywood films such as *F1* and *Jurassic World*. I

think it's very encouraging that cinema is very much in the fabric of Indian culture, and we are at the forefront of providing this service to the consumers," he added.

On the future outlook, he said, "The content pipeline for FY27 remains highly encouraging, with a strong mix of franchise films, star-led tentpoles, large-scale spectacles and content-driven titles across languages. The diversity and scale of this pipeline gives us strong confidence in the theatrical outlook for the fiscal."

SCREEN PRESENCE

In FY26, the leading multiplex chain added 93 screens and exited 18 underperforming screens taking the total screen count to 1,798 across 359 cinemas in 113 cities in India and Sri Lanka. It has been focusing on opening

new screens in under-penetrated markets with nearly 45 per cent new screens added in southern India.

"We will continue to add 100-odd screens annually. Capital-light formats accounted for 55 per cent of new screen additions. We have now tested the waters with the asset-light model and the FOCO model; this model will continue to contribute 50-60 per cent of new screens, while the balance being our own capital," he added.

Bijli noted that share of premium formats such as IMAX, 4DX and Director's Cut, has grown to 16 per cent of the overall portfolio.

"So on the one hand we are opening new screens in tier-2 and -3 markets, and on the other, also expanding our premium format sceens," he added.

IHCL profit rises 15% in Q4 on domestic biz growth

Our Bureau
Mumbai



UAE BUSINESS. IHCL has three hotels in Dubai, and they form a very small share of overall business

Indian Hotels Company Ltd (IHCL) reported 15 per cent increase in consolidated net profit in the fourth quarter of FY26, led by growth in domestic business. Net profit for the quarter stood at ₹600 crore as against ₹522 crore in the same period last year. While the West Asia conflict slowed down business in March, the company posted 14 per cent year-on-year growth in revenue to ₹2,845 crore in Q4FY26.

Domestic revenue got an upside from meetings, events and conferences, but international business suffered due to flight cancellations. Occupancy at its Dubai hotels dropped to 25 per cent in the March quarter impacting fee in-

come. Earning before interest tax depreciation and amortisation rose 15 per cent to ₹1,052 crore and margins were flat at 37 per cent.

DUBAI IMPACT

"We would have seen higher revenue growth — perhaps 15 per cent or 16 per cent. The first two months were good and then business slipped in March and the first

half of April. We saw a pick-up again in the second half of April and May," IHCL Managing Director and CEO, Puneet Chhatwal, said.

The company has three hotels in Dubai and they form a very small share of overall business. Chhatwal said diversification of portfolio has helped the company navigate the challenges. "In this fiscal, we will open 60 hotels and will continue to

deliver double-digit revenue growth," he said.

IHCL will invest around ₹1,200 crore in capex towards room refurbishment and expansion in the current fiscal. In the past two years, it has spent around ₹3,200 crore in capex.

Chhatwal said the company maintains a healthy balance sheet with a gross cash balance of Rs ₹4,345 crore and has proposed a 44 per cent increase in dividend over last year.

businessline.

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Trump’s China challenges

Iran, trade issues will dominate Trump-Xi talks

Sridhar Krishnaswami

Less than a week before his much awaited visit and in a summit with his Chinese counterpart Xi Jinping, US President Donald Trump has firmly rejected any notion that China is challenging the US over the war with Iran stressing his “very good” relationship.

“We haven’t been challenged by China. They don’t challenge us” adding that Xi “wouldn’t do that... I don’t think he’d do that because of me”. Separately, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio has said that Beijing was the worst hit by the closure of the Strait of Hormuz urging China to push Tehran to open the crucial navigation line. It is not as if Iran is suddenly making the headlines ahead of Trump’s impending visit to China. Since the war started on February 28, Beijing has been expressing its opposition to the hostilities and in the aftermath of the shutting down the Hormuz has been calling upon Iran to keep the vital international waterways open.

China is the largest buyer of Iranian crude in the upwards of 80 per cent and the billions of dollars in revenue generated reportedly bankrolling about 45 per cent of Iranian government’s budget. More important, it is said that 50 per cent of all China’s imports come through the Strait of Hormuz.

China is Iran’s largest trading partner with official bilateral trade pegged at around \$14 billion, which is said to exclude “significant” unofficial oil transactions through third country intermediaries to evade American sanctions. And in 2021 Tehran and Beijing signed a 25-year cooperation agreement that pledged \$400 billion investment in Iran’s energy, infrastructure and technology sectors.

CHINA’S INTERESTS

But media reports speak of very little of this having come through primarily because of hesitancy of Chinese companies due sanctions restrictions. In fact China’s interest in seeing a quick end to the war in Iran is also because of its extensive economic interests in the Middle East especially in Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates that go far beyond energy to include investment, technology and market opportunities for Chinese companies.

Even without the war in Iran, Trump would have had a plate full



US President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping (file photo) REUTERS

during the summit for China is one of the largest export markets for the US and for China, the US is its top export market. The biggest trade friction has been Washington running a trade deficit in the upwards of \$200 billion which has been coming down; but a surplus of about \$34 billion in services. Often forgotten in all the rhetoric on trade surplus, tariffs and sanctions is China’s huge holding of US Treasury bonds — a whopping \$760 billion. China is the second largest foreign creditor to the US after Japan.

In spite of a close relationship with Iran, China has been measured in its role in the Middle East war. Undoubtedly Beijing has called for cessation of hostilities and keeping the Hormuz open; but offering only diplomatic support to Tehran at international forums like the United Nations. There have been some unverified reports of China supplying weapons or components for Iranian missiles but even Trump has sought to downplay these purported transactions.

“I wrote him a letter asking him not to do that, and he wrote me a letter to say that, essentially, he’s not doing that”, Trump said in a recent interview. In fact Beijing has always carefully distanced itself from Tehran’s regional policies, especially regarding its proxies like the Hamas, Hezbollah and the Houthis.

Xi will want to come away with as much as he can on Taiwan and the South China Seas with nations eagerly perked up to see how the two leaders address outstanding concerns in a vital part of the world. Coming to an agreement with Iran including keeping the Strait of Hormuz open may get Trump the “big, fat hug” from Xi but the rest of Indo-Pacific is hopeful of its interests protected at the summit.

The writer is a senior journalist who has reported from Washington DC on North America and United Nations



The ASEAN+3’s Samarkand decision for a safety net to guard against financial volatility is still shrouded in uncertainty

MACROSCAN.



CP CHANDRASHEKHAR, JAYATI GHOSH

On May 3, Finance Ministers and Central Bank Governors from the ASEAN+3 grouping (consisting of 10 ASEAN members and China, Japan and South Korea) issued a statement, following meetings in Samarkand, Uzbekistan. It recognised that the “conflict in the Middle East” had increased risks for the East and Southeast Asian region, requiring attention to the possibility of “excessive volatility and disorderly movements in financial markets and shifts in global liquidity conditions.” In response, the ASEAN+3 governments are working to amend the Chiang Mai Initiative Multilateralisation (CMIM) arrangement, a network of dollar swaps backed by reserves of central banks in the region.

The amendment, when implemented, would transition the CMIM from being a “contributory arrangement”, with members pledging to release promised funds when any other member requests emergency financing, to being a “Paid-in Capital” Fund, where contributions are actually made upfront and transferred to a special legal entity, making it immediately available as and when required by balance of payments stressed countries.

This would bring the regional arrangement closest to an Asian Monetary Fund, or a regional alternative to the IMF — an idea that was mooted by Japan after the 1997 South-East Asian financial crisis and shot down by the US and the IMF, for fear of loss of their influence.

There is still some uncertainty as to whether the transition would go through. ASEAN+3 members have even now agreed only on three of the four principles that would govern the creation and functioning of the entity that would host and manage the paid-in corpus — these are that this legal entity must be independent of the member countries; it must recruit and deploy expert managerial and other personnel (to match the IMF perhaps); and that the system must be designed for effective coordination between its surveillance and lending functions.

STUMBLING BLOCKS

But divergent national interests, the ASEAN statement confesses, have held back agreement on the fourth principle of ensuring a ‘sound management structure’, involving the all-important decision-making systems and oversight frameworks of the proposed independent entity.

This is no small matter. The effort to create a regional financial safety net in East and South-East Asia, has a long and tortuous history.

It began almost five decades back in August 1977 when, faced with the uncertainties generated by the oil shocks, central banks and monetary authorities from the original ASEAN members (Indonesia, Malaysia, The Philippines, Singapore and Thailand) committed to providing “immediate short-term swap facilities to participating ASEAN member countries with temporary international liquidity problems.”

The Arrangement provided for “the sale of US dollars against the domestic currency of the requesting participant,” along with a forward purchase of the same amount of domestic currency by the requesting participant for US dollars.

The facility was backed by “pledges to provide”, with members agreeing to share the burden of supporting requests for emergency balance of payments financing.

The arrangement has changed much over these five decades. One continuous change has been an expansion of the implicit ‘corpus’ backing the ASA, which began in 1977 at a small and inadequate \$100 million, touched \$2 billion in 2005. That was inadequate, since this was a period when, following liberalisation of the capital account, the balance and payments vulnerability of LMICs increased because of recurrent exit of foreign finance in a trajectory characterised by boom-bust financial flow cycles.

That necessitated substantially increasing the dollar commitments that back any meaningful financial safety net. At that time such a hike could not have been supported by just the ASEAN countries. But since the collateral effects of the South-East Asian crisis also affected the more developed countries in the region — China, Japan and South Korea — they were willing to support the safety net, resulting in the creation of the ASEAN+3 and the integration of the ASA into the Chiang Mai Initiative (CMI) in 2009.

The CMI had two pillars. One was an enhanced ASEAN swap arrangement, with contributions now set at \$1 billion. The second pillar was a network of “bilateral” swap arrangements under which countries could request a swap of their currencies for dollars up to an agreed amount.

The CMI provided for negotiation of 33 bilateral currency swap arrangements of which 30 were between each of the Northeast Asian nations (China, Japan and South Korea) and each of the 10 ASEAN members and three were

The initial understanding was that of the total pool of \$120 billion, 80 per cent would be contributed by the Plus 3 countries and the rest by ASEAN countries

CMIM contributions as of 2009

	\$ billion	%
Plus three	96	80
China total	38.4	32
China	34.2	28.5
Hong Kong	4.2	3.5
Japan	38.4	32
South Korea	19.2	16
ASEAN	24	20
Indonesia	4.77	3.79
Malaysia	4.77	3.79
Philippines	3.68	3.79
Singapore	4.77	3.79
Thailand	4.77	3.79
Vietnam	1	0.83
Cambodia	0.12	0.1
Myanmar	0.06	0.05
Laos	0.03	0.03
Brunei	0.01	0.03
ASEAN+3	120	100

between the Northeast Asian nations themselves. This helped raise the dollar surpluses committed to backing the ASEAN financial safety net to a much higher \$120 billion in 2009 and \$240 billion in 2014.

However, the system was still one involving bilateral swap arrangements, besides being backed only with “pledges” rather than an actual corpus into which dollar funds were transferred.

BILATERAL VS MULTILATERAL

In fact, the problem with the CMI was the large bilateral component of what was a multilateral arrangement. This meant decision making and implementation were cumbersome, slow and uncertain.

This inadequacy appeared stark after the 2007 financial crisis and was addressed by ASEAN+3 Finance Ministers in May 2009 with a decision that the arrangement must be multilateralised and transitioned to the Chiang Mai Initiative Multilateralised (CMIM).

The initial understanding was that of the total pool of \$120 billion, 80 per cent would be contributed by the Plus 3 countries and the rest by ASEAN countries.

One issue was how the commitments to the pool would be distributed, since that would determine the relative influence (in the form of voting rights) of the different players, especially the plus-3 countries.

Given the need to balance the influence of contesting powers China and Japan, China (along with Hong Kong) was allotted \$38.4 billion in contributions and proportionate voting rights, which equalled that of Japan (see table). That distribution remained when the “pledged corpus” was increased to

\$240 billion in July 2014 with no other change of significance.

SURVEILLANCE ISSUE

There was one more hurdle to cross. If and when large loans were provided, there was need for some degree of surveillance to ensure that the country “borrowing” dollars via the swap would be in a position to return the dollars and settle the transaction when the swap agreement expires.

Neither China nor Japan would have liked to give the other the right to surveillance of the funding it provides through the now-multilateralised “pool” of bilateral swaps. To address this problem, while the rules governing individual swaps were left to be bilaterally negotiated, it was agreed that there was “need to establish a link with the IMF for surveillance and monitoring, as a substitute for regional conditionality and monitoring”.

Beyond a specified borrowing limit, a borrower from the CMIM was required to have entered into an agreement with the IMF and be subject to the latter’s conditionality and surveillance to be eligible for support. Initially any swap in excess of 10 per cent of the agreed amount in an arrangement required IMF surveillance. That was raised to 20, 30 and 40 per cent subsequently.

With hindsight we now know that nothing came of these cooperation efforts.

Countries preferred to turn to the US Federal Reserve or bilateral swap agreements outside the CMIM in times of emergency.

On the other hand, the CMIM has not been activated even once since its inception, despite balance of payments volatility.

The principal explanation for that failure was the subordination of the regional agreement to the IMF.

If obtaining a small sum from the CMIM safety net required IMF endorsement with a conditional loan, countries may as well opt for a direct and large loan, and the accompanying conditionality and surveillance, from the IMF.

Seen in this background the Samarkand promise to transition the CMIM from a “promise-to-pay” swap system to a Paid-in Capital (PiC) structure, which would make the war chest more easily accessible to balance of payments distressed countries while significant, is by no means transformational.

What needs to be addressed is the ability of the regional arrangement to be able to take decisions on lending without having to rely on surveillance by the IMF.

This makes the still absent agreement on the “fourth principle” on decision making structures and surveillance mechanisms extremely significant. If that is not resolved, either the PiC structure will not be formalised, or it will take a form in which once again utilisation will be minimal.

thehindubusinessline. TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

May 12, 2006

Market plunges on Left’s ascent

The electoral victory of the Left front in Kerala and West Bengal appears to have cast a shadow on the stock markets on Thursday. The BSE Sensex, which opened firm, reversed its course mid-way on news reports that the Left would increase pressure on the coalition Government at the Centre. The benchmark BSE-30 Sensex dropped by 176.97 points or 1.40 per cent to 12,435.41.

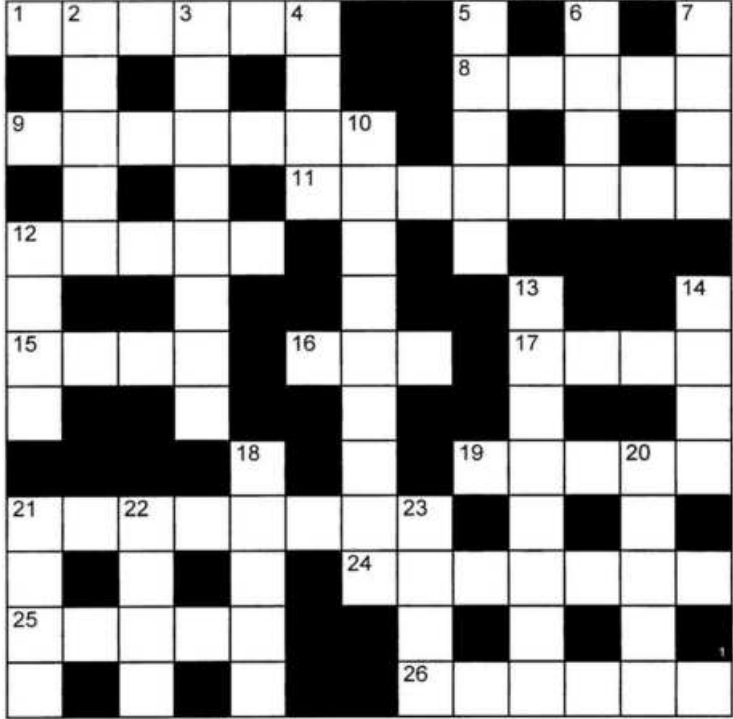
Monsanto curbed from charging Rs 900 for Bt cotton seeds

The Monopolies and Restrictive Trade Practices Commission (MRTPC) has directed the US biotech major, Monsanto not to charge the trait value of Rs 900 for a packet of 450 gm for Bt cotton seeds in an interim order pronounced in the court on Thursday.

Burmans’ set to take over Punjab Tractors

The Burman family seems firmly on track to take over the reins of Punjab Tractors Ltd (PTL). The family’s representative on the PTL board, Mr P.D. Narang, on Thursday was appointed non-executive Chairman of the tractor company at a board meeting. He replaces Mr S.K. Tuteja.

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2677



EASY

ACROSS

- Winged heavenly infant (6)
- The precincts, circuit (5)
- Blame, reproof (7)
- Out of one’s mind (8)
- Money-lending at high interest (5)
- Plunge head-first (4)
- Is allowed to (3)
- Bucket (4)
- Baby’s comforter (5)
- Baggage-animal handler (8)
- Childish fit of rage (7)
- Long-spiked garden flower (5)
- Tank gun-housing (6)

DOWN

- Gets ball back from scrum (5)
- Bead-strings used in prayer (8)
- Member of the Aves (4)
- Place of safe retreat (5)
- Death notice in paper (abbr) (4)
- Collar fastener (4)
- Container for Anguillidae (3-6)
- Untie knot (4)
- Articulate in fury (8)
- Be engaged in sport (4)
- Detached piece of rock (5)
- Timid, colourless person (5)
- Nourishing fluid (4)
- Mouth-parts (4)
- Declaim bombastically, storm (4)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

- Junior reporter takes her in, a chubby-cheeked child (6)
- Before midday, a part is devoted to the precincts (5)
- Chapter-leader will make certain of telling-off (7)
- Indeed, it meant a loss that made one crazy (8)
- Overmuch interest is taken in us taking a turn on railway (5)
- Get beneath the surface of such a low haunt (4)
- It is allowed to blossom: but when? (3)
- Bucket-shop might supply it to friend one included (4)
- Ventriloquist’s model sort of comforter (5)
- His charges, they say, are known to be stubborn (8)
- With so much French spirit a show of temper is produced (7)
- Flower coming up in an incomplete row (5)
- It holds lathe-operator’s cutter for a tank-top (6)

DOWN

- Lists how one makes partial shoe repair for cads (5)
- Almost got up a sign of the Zodiac with rows of beads (8)
- Flighty thing done by those sentenced (4)
- A restful place in Paradise abandoned by Eve finally (5)
- Ring piece newspapers publish shortly as a memorial (4)
- Breeding farm may be collared by the boss (4)
- Best a keel can provide is a holder for a sort of fish (3-6)
- Resolve the sound it made, losing head (4)
- Spy didn’t finish turning turtle, and will speak with fury (8)
- Such a drama may be merely recreation (4)
- Weight of this however is expressed in carats (5)
- Creature for doctor in the army to employ for black eye (5)
- Sort of bar that may give one the shakes (4)
- Devices for pouring such as meet in osculation (4)
- Wild outcry at its inclusion in an improper anthology (4)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2676

ACROSS 1. Down-hearted 8. Extracts 9. Bath 10. Psalm 13. Rain 16. Moor 17. Maze 18. Neat 20. Emend 24. Army 25. Practise 26. Out-patients

DOWN 2. Oath 3. Nears 4. Extol 5. Tiber 6. Detrimental 7. Changes over 11. Alive 12. Midge 14. Alas 15. Nova 19. Tryst 21. Merit 22. Niche 23. List

QUICKLY.

BSE launches F&O on Focused IT Index



New Delhi: BSE on Monday launched futures and options (F&O) contracts on the BSE Focused IT Index, becoming the only stock exchange in the country to offer derivatives on an information technology sector . The BSE Focused IT Index comprises 14 leading technology companies and is designed to provide investors with a focused benchmark for the country's information technology sector, the exchange said. The launch coincided with National Technology Day and is aimed at offering investors an additional tool to hedge, trade and manage risks linked to the IT sector. On the first day of trading, 172 members participated in the new product, generating a turnover of ₹148 crore. **m**

BofA Securities settles insider trading norms case

New Delhi: SEBI on Monday settled proceedings against BofA Securities India after the merchant banker paid ₹58.5 lakh towards the settlement amount in a case related to alleged violation of insider trading norms. SEBI had initiated adjudication proceedings against BofA Securities India for alleged violation of provisions under the Prohibition of Insider Trading regulations and Merchant Bankers rules. According to SEBI, it was alleged that BofA Securities India, being a merchant banker, failed to maintain the Structured Digital Database as prescribed under PIT regulations. **m**

Northern Arc jumps 8% on solid Q4 show, gets thumbs up from analysts

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Northern Arc Capital shares rallied on Monday after the non-banking financial company reported a nearly three-fold jump in net profit for the March quarter, driven by strong growth in interest income and improvement in asset quality. The stock settled 8 per cent positive at ₹310.75, hitting a 52-week high of ₹321.70 against the previous close of ₹287.30. Post market hours on Friday, the company posted a net profit of ₹139 crore in Q4FY26 compared with ₹47 crore in the corresponding quarter last year. Total income rose to ₹735 crore (₹593 crore), while net interest income increased 21 per cent y-o-y to ₹387 crore. Total expenditure stood at ₹552 crore during the quarter compared with ₹545 crore in the year-ago period. Asset quality improved during the quarter, with gross

PM's austerity talk sinks jewellery, travel stocks; charges up EV shares

CAUTIOUSLY HOPEFUL. Analysts see near-term demand pressure on jewellers ahead of festive, wedding season

Madhu Balaji
Bengaluru

Jewellery and tourism-related stocks witnessed sharp selling pressure on Monday after Prime Minister Narendra Modi urged citizens to curb discretionary spending on gold purchases, overseas travel and fuel consumption to help reduce pressure on India's foreign exchange reserves amid rising geopolitical tensions in West Asia. However, electric vehicle and green mobility stocks rallied on expectations of faster EV adoption following the government's push towards fuel conservation. Modi asked people to reduce petrol and diesel usage by relying more on metros and public transport, avoid unnecessary overseas travel,

Hope and despair

Jewellery stocks	Close (₹)	% Change	EV	Close (₹)	% Change
Titan	4,205.6	-6.73	Ather Energy	969.45	5.95
Kalyan Jewellers	385.2	-9.27	Ola Electric	36.97	2.47
Thangamayil	4,007.1	-5.64	Olectra Green	1,370	2.19
PN Gadgil	662.35	-9.01	Tours & Travel		
Sky Gold	505.2	-6.66	Le Travenues	163.1	-3.14
PNGS Reva	417.65	-8.46	Easy Trip	7.68	-3.52
Bluestone	474.05	-5.95	BLS Intl	284.9	-1.52

and defer non-essential gold purchases for one year. Jewellery stocks bore the brunt of the selling pressure amid concerns over weaker near-term demand. Titan Company shares settled 6.73 per cent lower at ₹4,205.60. Kalyan Jewellers tumbled over 9 per cent to ₹385.20. Shares of PN Gadgil, Senco Gold, Thangamayil Jewellery, BlueStone Jewellery and Sky Gold and Dia-

monds slumped about 9 per cent. **FOREX EFFECT** Khushi Mistry, Research Analyst, Bonanza, said the jewellery sector may see near-term demand pressure ahead of the festive and wedding season, although India's culturally entrenched gold demand is unlikely to witness a lasting impact without policy measures such as

higher import duties. Among travel and tourism-linked stocks, InterGlobe Aviation, the parent company of IndiGo, plunged 5 per cent to ₹4,299.40 on the NSE amid concerns that moderation in leisure and international travel demand could impact passenger traffic growth. Hospitality stocks such as ITC Hotels, Mahindra Holidays & Resorts India, Indian Hotels Company, Leela Palaces and Chalet Hotels were also down 1-3 per cent. Travel booking-related stocks also saw selling, with Le Travenues Technology falling 3 per cent to ₹163.10 and Yatra Online tanking over 5 per cent to ₹102.31. Mistry of Bonanza said the outbound tourism and aviation segment appears more vulnerable because overseas vacations and destination

weddings are discretionary expenses that consumers can postpone easily. However, domestic tourism, hospitality and resort operators could benefit if travellers increasingly shift to local vacations, he said. **EV STOCKS SOAR** Meanwhile, electric vehicle and green mobility stocks gained sharply led by Ather Energy that gained 6 per cent higher at ₹969.45. JBM Auto shares closed 5 per cent higher at ₹681.65. Ola Electric Mobility shares also gained over 2 per cent to settle at ₹36.97. Market experts said the government's renewed push towards fuel conservation and reduced dependence on imported crude oil could accelerate electric vehicle adoption over the medium term.

Nifty slips below 24,000 amid uncertainty, FPIs pull out ₹2 lakh cr in 2026

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai



Equities took a beating on Monday as the collapse of US-Iran peace talks sent crude oil surging past \$100 a barrel, rattling investor sentiment from the opening bell. The sell-off, which intensified sharply in the second half of the session, reflected a market suddenly confronted with the twin threats of imported inflation and a weakening rupee — a combination that historically squeezes India's current account and corporate margins simultaneously. Aggressive selling by foreign portfolio investors, which crossed over ₹2-lakh crore in 2026, kept the market under pressure. "...selling pressure was broad-based, with most sectoral indices closing lower... the sharp correction was primarily triggered by a spike in crude oil prices following renewed geopolitical tensions surrounding the US-Iran situation," said Ajit Mishra, SVP Research, Religare Broking. The Nifty 50 ended the session down 360.30 points to close at 23,815.85 — its lowest in three weeks — while the Sensex shed 1312.91 points to settle at 76,015.28. The Nifty Midcap 100 and Smallcap 100 fell 1.05 per cent and 1.13 per cent, respectively. Within the Nifty 500 universe, 382 stocks ended in the red. India VIX surged over 10 per cent to 18.5, signalling a sharp jump in market anxiety. US President Donald Trump's rejection of Iran's peace proposal — dismissing demands around the Strait of Hormuz blockade, compensation, and sovereignty recognition as "totally unacceptable" — was the immediate catalyst. With the Strait re-

maining shut, Brent crude surged roughly 4 per cent to around \$105.7 a barrel, deepening concerns over India's import bill. Domestic crude futures climbed above ₹9,200. Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal urging citizens to avoid gold purchases, reduce fuel consumption, and defer non-essential foreign travel added another layer of concern. Markets read the message as a signal that the government is worried about mounting pressure on foreign exchange reserves. On the sectoral front, Consumer Durables fell 3.7 per cent, and Realty declined sharply, while Pharma and Healthcare were the only sectors to eke out marginal gains, benefiting from their defensive character and the rupee-depreciation tailwind on export earnings.

HSBC BULLISH ON US The turbulence in emerging markets contrasted with a relatively more optimistic outlook for Wall Street. HSBC Global Investment Research on Monday raised its year-end S&P 500 target to 7,650 from 7,500, citing an 8 per cent upward revision in 2026 earnings estimates following a strong Q1 season. The bank also flagged that a broader sentiment rebound in tech and AI — combined with easing geopolitical and macro concerns — could potentially push the index past 8,000, even as it cautioned that elevated crude prices and a hawkish Fed pivot remain key downside risks.

Depositories may get to use IPF income for trust expenses

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

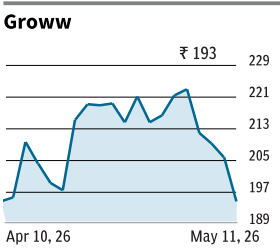
Markets regulator SEBI on Monday proposed allowing depositories to use up to 5 per cent of the interest or income earned from investments of their Investor Protection Fund (IPF) corpus to meet expenses related to the administration of the IPF Trust. The proposal aims to align the framework for depositories with the existing provisions applicable to stock exchanges. Accordingly, in its consultation paper, SEBI said, "To meet expenses related

to dedicated employees of IPF Trust of the depository, other administrative and statutory expenses such as applicable taxes, audit fees and charity commissioner's fee, etc, subject to a maximum of 5 per cent of such interest or income from investments of the IPF during the year may be permitted to be utilised by the depository". Currently, 100 per cent of interest or income from the IPF is treated as corpus of IPF and all expenses are to be incurred by the depositories from their own income even if such expenses directly relate to IPF Trust.

Investors to sell ₹4,750 crore worth shares of Groww via block deal

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Early investors in Billionbrains Garage Ventures, the parent of stockbroking platform Groww, are set to pare stake through a block deal worth about ₹4,750 crore (\$498 million), according to the term sheet of the transaction. The selling investors include Peak XV Partners Investments VI-1, Sequoia Capital Global Growth Fund III — US/India Annex Fund LP, YC Holdings II LLC of Y Combinator and entities affiliated with Ribbit Capital.



The proposed share sale involves up to 26.84 crore shares, representing around 4.3 per cent of the company's existing total shares outstanding. **FLOOR PRICE: ₹177** The floor price for the deal has been set at ₹177 per

share, reflecting an 8.5 per cent discount to Monday's closing price of ₹193.52 on the NSE. The term sheet said an up-sizing option remains "to be updated". The deal carries a 90-day lock-up period for the selling shareholders. The block deal is expected to be conducted on Tuesday. Kotak Securities Ltd and JP Morgan India Private Ltd are acting as placement agents for the transaction. Billionbrains Garage Ventures reported a strong financial performance in Q4 FY26, driven by rapid revenue growth and expanding profitability.

BROKER'S CALL.

Anand Rathi Research

BLUE STAR (BUY)

Target: ₹1,964
CMP: ₹1,660.40
Blue Star reported a soft performance in Q4FY26, with just 1.3 per cent year-on-year revenue growth, led by muted performance of UCP and EMP segments. However, cost rationalisation measures and deferment of discretionary cost aided margin expansion. EMP business' outlook remains strong with steady growth, driven by robust OB, manufacturing capex and data centre demand with stable margin. Although secondary sales improved from mid-April 2026, demand outlook remains contingent on summer intensity and channel offtake. High industry competition may limit full pass-through of cost, especially during the peak season. Margin is expected to remain range-bound, with likely gradual improvement in the near term. The management has reiterated segmental EBIT margin guidance at 8-8.5 per cent, with an additional about 5 per cent price hike expected in Q1FY27 to offset elevated input cost. It also targets about 15 per cent market share. UCP (RAC) is likely to see demand recovery in Q1FY27, contingent on summer intensity and channel restocking, though margin may remain range-bound due to competitive intensity, partial cost pass-through and volatility in raw material cost despite planned price hike. Considering modest quarterly performance and guidance, we tweak our EPS estimate by 9-10 per cent. We maintain Buy rating on the stock with a lower TP of ₹1,964 (₹2,188 earlier), valuing it at 44x FY28E EPS of ₹45.

Asit C Mehta Investment

HYUNDAI MOTOR INDIA (HOLD)

Target: ₹1,960
CMP: ₹1,907.10
Hyundai Motor India's Q4FY26 Revenue/EBITDA/PAT missed estimates by 2.5 per cent/18.9 per cent/16.8 per cent. Revenue grew 5.4 per cent y-o-y, led by volume growth, but came below estimates due to a decline in ASPs, driven by a higher share of lower-priced models such as Aura and i10. EBITDA fell 22.4 per cent. PAT declined 22.2 per cent. The key positive from the quarter was the management's confident FY27E volume outlook, with HMLI guiding for 8-10 per cent domestic volume growth, implying potential market share gains. Growth is expected to be supported by the new Venue ramp-up and two new SUV launches, a localised compact EV SUV and an ICE mid-SUV above 4 metres. . However, West Asia disruption remains a near-term risk, making export recovery and market diversification key monitorables. Margins are likely to remain under pressure in the near term due to elevated commodity prices, Pune ramp-up costs and launch-related expenses. HMLI has taken about 60-bp price hike in January, followed by a selective Venue price hike in March, with another planned in May. We believe HMLI is entering FY27E with better growth visibility than FY26, supported by capacity availability, a stronger SUV pipeline and export resilience. On FY28E EPS of ₹85.3, we value HMLI at a P/E multiple of 23x, arriving at a target price of ₹1,960 per share. We retain our Hold rating on the stock.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: **blmarketwatch@gmail.com**

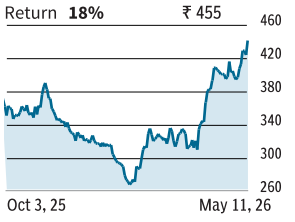
TODAY'S PICK.

Shilpa Medicare (₹455.35): BUY

Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau

The short-term outlook is bullish for Shilpa Medicare. The stock closed over 4 per cent on Monday when the broader markets were beaten down badly. The 21-Day Moving Average (DMA), currently at ₹420 has given very good support for the stock recently. The 55-DMA is on the verge of making a bullish crossover with the 200-DMA. This strengthens the bullish case and indicates that the downside could be limited. Shilpa Medicare share price has potential to target ₹535-₹540 in the coming weeks. Traders can go buy the stock now at ₹455. Accumulate on dips at ₹440.

Shilpa Medicare



Keep the stop-loss at ₹405 initially. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹465 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹480. Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹485 and ₹505 when the price touches ₹495 and ₹520, respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹530. Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

23860 » Nifty 50 Futures					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
23850	23740	24050	24170	Go short on a break below 23850 with a stop-loss at 23870	
₹766 » HDFC Bank					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
762	750	770	778	Take fresh shorts below 762 with a stop-loss at 764	
₹1176 » Infosys					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
1170	1155	1190	1200	Go short only below 1170. Keep the stop-loss at 1175	
₹306 » ITC					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
303	300	308	310	Go short now and at 307. Keep the stop-loss at 309	
₹281 » ONGC					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
278	275	283	287	Go long on a break above 283 with a stop-loss at 281	
₹1386 » Reliance Ind.					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
1370	1340	1400	1420	Go short now and at 1395. Keep the stop-loss at 1405	
₹976 » SBI					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
966	950	985	1000	Go long on a bounce from 966 with a stop-loss at 962	
₹2400 » TCS					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
2370	2345	2420	2440	Go short now and at 2415. Stop-loss can be kept at 2425	
S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.					

Nifty 50 Movers ▼ 360.30 pts.					
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
TataConsumerProduct	1271.00	13.46	81.31	0.76	
Sun Pharma	1872.70	5.73	41.02	1.82	
Max Healthcare	1037.95	4.13	71.17	0.71	
Coal India	464.45	3.99	9.21	0.97	
Hind Unilever	2307.20	3.77	51.23	1.87	
Axis Bank	1272.30	2.50	14.89	3.34	
ICICI Bank	1266.40	2.49	15.65	8.29	
ONGC	281.00	1.52	7.86	1.00	
Grasim Ind	2984.20	1.29	21.44	1.04	
SBI Life	1384.40	1.21	76.30	0.77	
Adani Ports	1737.30	1.11	31.86	1.19	
Kotak Bank	381.05	0.40	19.65	2.57	
HDFC Life	622.70	0.23	70.26	0.61	
NestleIndia	1481.90	-0.08	81.67	0.97	
TCS	2392.90	-0.33	17.51	2.24	
Apollo Hosp	8062.00	-0.34	62.28	0.76	
Adani Enter	2500.20	-0.36	32.46	0.66	
Wipro	196.68	-0.77	15.55	0.51	
Tech Mahindra	1457.40	-0.78	29.71	0.85	
HCL Tech	1194.90	-0.81	19.47	1.15	
Infosys	1177.00	-1.68	16.19	3.78	
Dr Reddy's Lab	1279.90	-1.86	19.34	0.71	
UltraTech Cement	1186.00	-2.17	42.70	1.29	
Bajaj Auto	10959.50	-2.80	28.01	1.07	
Trent Ltd.	4181.10	-2.96	86.35	0.85	
Eicher Motors	7202.50	-3.00	36.88	0.91	
PowerGrid Corp	310.90	-3.01	18.63	1.29	
Bajaj Finserv	1794.20	-3.03	14.60	0.95	
JSW Steel	1262.60	-3.11	39.76	1.08	
Asian Paints	246.33	-3.32	62.95	1.02	
ITC	305.85	-3.36	18.51	2.70	
Tata Motors PV	346.00	-4.32	47.05	0.66	
Tata Steel	212.08	-4.34	29.02	1.60	
Cipla	1304.90	-5.16	23.25	0.67	
Bharat Elec	431.95	-6.05	52.99	1.42	
Jet Financial Services Ltd.	256.20	-6.32	62.95	1.02	
Hindalco	1023.50	-6.60	14.31	1.36	
Maruti Suzuki	13483.00	-6.95	28.88	1.62	
L&T	3940.20	-8.78	28.60	4.24	
NTPC	392.95	-9.51	15.35	1.71	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	975.95	-9.71	22.90	1.25	
InterGlobeAvi	2555.80	-10.62	37.56	0.89	
Bajaj Finance	936.05	-11.26	30.13	2.30	
M&M	3245.90	-16.46	21.68	2.66	
Eternal Ltd.	245.87	-16.52	648.29	1.62	
Titan	4205.60	-27.30	73.58	1.59	
State Bank	973.60	-41.35	10.37	3.70	
Bharti Airtel	1759.80	-49.39	28.94	4.35	
HDFC Bank	151.65	-57.60	14.84	1.76	
Reliance Ind	1388.20	-69.22	19.62	8.58	
Pts: Impact on index movement					
Nifty Next 50 Movers ▼ 1,197.75 pts.					
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Torrent Pharma	4517.10	40.24	67.29	1.90	
Adanigenreenergy	1387.70	30.19	115.04	1.07	
Hyundai Motor India .	1906.90	21.78	28.53	1.89	
Zydusfsciences	956.95	11.93	19.16	0.96	
Bank Of Baroda	266.00	11.00	6.85	1.98	
Solar Industries	16263.00	10.87	96.39	1.59	
Vedanta	298.40	9.35	7.36	2.04	
Divis Lab	6714.00	1.26	71.90	3.43	
Limintree	4352.20	0.63	25.90	1.62	
AvenueSuper	4389.40	-5.28	96.16	1.60	
Siemens Energy India .	3157.80	-6.34	95.20	1.12	
Hindus Zinc	629.10	-7.34	19.22	1.10	
Tata Capital	314.95	-8.23	27.33	0.55	
Shree Cement	25205.00	-8.68	52.01	1.35	
United Spirits	1266.10	-12.26	53.54	1.50	
Adani Energy Solutions .	1340.40	-12.93	67.29	1.87	
Tata Power	433.20	-13.23	27.64	2.91	
Union Bank	163.81	-13.26	6.44	1.27	
Ambuja Cements	436.20	-13.95	19.62	1.07	
Indian Railway Finance Corp	103.08	-16.75	19.23	0.83	
Hindustanaeronautics	4756.30	-17.03	35.76	3.62	
Jindal Steel	1232.00	-17.15	37.39	1.83	
Magazzan Dock	2555.80	-19.62	37.56	0.78	
Bosch	37315.00	-20.32	39.92	2.30	
Samvardmotherinternatl	130.30	-21.61	37.79	2.32	
Macrotech Developers .	931.10	-24.64	27.11	1.05	
Bajaj Holdings	10425.00	-25.30	11.85	1.81	
Punjab Natl Bank	104.62	-25.50	6.51	1.45	
Muthoodfin	3438.20	-27.46	15.95	1.48	
Rural Elec	574.68	-27.68	14.84	1.76	

QUICKLY.

Persistent Systems gets nod for Arrka merger

New Delhi: IT services firm Persistent Systems on Monday said the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) has approved the merger of its wholly-owned subsidiary, Arrka Infosec Private Ltd, with the parent company. In a filing to the stock exchanges, Persistent Systems stated that it has received the certified true copy (CTC) of the order issued by the Mumbai bench of the NCLT. ■

PPL profit dips in fourth quarter to ₹156 crore

New Delhi: Fertilizer manufacturer Paradeep Phosphates Ltd (PPL) reported a 9.63 per cent decline in consolidated net profit to ₹155.60 crore for the fourth quarter of 2025-26, weighed down by elevated expenses. The Bhubaneswar-based company had posted a net profit of ₹172.19 crore in the year-ago period, according to a regulatory filing. Total income for the January-March quarter rose to ₹4,701.97 crore from ₹4,193.96 crore a year earlier. ■

Consumers buying gold as an investment asset rather than as jewellery: Titan CFO

SHIFTING PREFERENCES. Rising prices of the yellow metal have driven demand for lighter, lower-carat options

bl.interview

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

Gold is increasingly viewed by Indian consumers as an investment asset rather than merely an adornment category, Titan Company CFO Ashok Sonthalia said, even as elevated prices continue to reshape jewellery-buying behaviour across the country.

In an interaction following the company's Q4FY26 results, the Titan executive said rising gold prices have increased consumer interest in jewellery and coins from a wealth-preservation perspective, while weddings remain a strong demand driver despite affordability pressures. At the same time, consumers are increasingly shifting towards lighter and lower-carat jewellery, with overall gold grammage



Elevated gold prices adversely affect product mix and put some pressure on margins as well

ASHOK SONTHALIA
Titan Company CFO



India has traditionally been a predominantly 22-carat jewellery market. Now we are seeing growing acceptance of 18-carat jewellery across many markets. That is one form of downtrending because it makes jewellery more affordable. It allows us to maintain accessible price points despite elevated gold prices.

If gold prices remain elevated over the next year, what does the outlook look like?

Gold has increasingly become an investment asset in addition to being an adornment category. Interest in gold from an investment perspective has gone up multi-fold. Indians still prefer investing in jewellery and coins rather than only through ETFs or financial instruments because jewellery also carries emotional and experiential value. Weddings continue to remain a very strong demand driver. That

versus price-led ticket-size inflation?

Q4 stood out after several muted quarters, with clear buyer growth. We broadly treat buyer growth as volume growth. About 8 per cent was buyer growth, while nearly 40 per cent was ticket-size growth driven by higher gold prices. Jewellery growth was around 46 per cent domestically and nearly 50 per cent on a consolidated basis.

Are consumers now visibly downtrending because of high gold prices?

shrinking across the industry. The company posted a growth in its consolidated net profit by 35 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) to ₹1,179 crore from ₹871 crore in Q4FY25. The total income has increased to ₹20,300 crore, an increase by 46 per cent y-o-y from ₹13,891 crore.

Edited excerpts:

Titan reported strong jewellery growth despite elevated gold prices. How much of the growth was driven by actual buyer growth

Crown Worldwide to take India investment to \$30 m, targets ₹500 cr revenue by 2030

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

After investing \$15 million in India over the past two years, Hong Kong-based logistics and information-management firm Crown Worldwide Group plans to double that commitment to \$30 million by investing another \$15 million over the next two years. The company is planning to expand its information management and workplace-services businesses, as rising demand from global capability centres (GCCs), hybrid-

work restructuring and stricter compliance under India's Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) framework reshape the market for enterprise infrastructure and data-governance solutions.

The investment reflects a broader shift in Crown's India strategy from a relocation-led logistics business to a higher-value enterprise platform spanning records management, document digitisation, workplace asset management and information-governance services. The privately-held com-

pany, which generates about \$600 million in annual global revenue, is targeting more than ₹500 crore in revenue from India by 2030, up from close to ₹300 crore in FY25. Executives said the India business is growing at 10-12 per cent annually, making it one of Crown's fastest-growing markets.

INDIA AMONG TOP 5

India has emerged as one of Crown's top five global markets and now contributes nearly 10 per cent of group revenue, highlighting the country's growing import-

ance in the company's Asia strategy.

As part of this expansion, Crown on Monday inaugurated a new facility in Coimbatore built on a 4.5-acre site. The centre has an initial capacity of more than 468,000 standard carton equivalents (SCE), with scope to expand to 720,000 SCE in a second phase through an additional 45,000 square feet.

The site will support Crown Information Management, Crown Relocations and Crown Workspace, including its Renew Centre,



Jennifer Harvey, Group CEO of Crown Worldwide Group

which focuses on refurbishing and reusing workplace assets. "India is one of our fastest-growing markets and

this new facility strengthens our ability to support clients with physical document and corporate asset storage, digitalisation and information-management solutions," Jennifer Harvey, Group CEO of Crown Worldwide Group, said.

Harvey said India is becoming increasingly important as Asian economies expand and demand rises for infrastructure partners capable of managing both physical and digital business assets across sectors such as banking, healthcare and legal services.

"We invest in markets with sustained growth and India continues to stand out in that regard," said Tze Shen Kong, Chief Executive Officer, Asia, Crown Worldwide Group.

"This facility significantly strengthens our ability to serve clients operating in and out of India."

Crown is also investing in AI-led document digitisation and workflow automation, while nearly 40 per cent of energy consumption across its Indian facilities is supported by renewable-energy infrastructure.

‘Policy push will lift Thales’ aerospace biz’

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

Global aerospace and defence technology major Thales said the proposed policy support for aero components manufacturing, rising defence expenditure and expansion of aviation infrastructure will strengthen India's manufacturing ecosystem.

Speaking to *businessline*, Ankur Kanagekar, Vice-President – India at Thales, said a PLI scheme for component manufacturing could encourage both domestic and global firms to expand manufacturing activity in India.

DUTY EXEMPTIONS

According to Kanagekar, the Budget 2026-27 allocation of ₹7.85 lakh crore for defence, marking a 15 per cent increase over the previous year, reflects continued emphasis on modernising and strengthening the armed forces. Similarly, customs duty exemptions on aircraft components, parts and raw



Ankur Kanagekar, Vice-President – India at Thales

materials used in maintenance, repair and overhaul (MRO) activities, Kanagekar said, indicate sustained policy backing for aerospace manufacturing.

He added that Thales plans to deepen partnerships with Indian industry while continuing investments in artificial intelligence and cyber technologies. On the civil aviation side, India's aviation market is expected to sustain growth, driven by passenger traffic expansion, fleet additions, airport modernisation and rising MRO demand.

As per government estimates, passenger traffic could grow six-fold to around 1.1 billion by 2040, while India's aircraft MRO market may reach \$4 billion by 2031.

Kanagekar cited the modified UDAN scheme, running from 2026 to 2036 with an outlay of ₹28,840 crore and focused on developing 100 airports from unserved air-strips, could improve regional connectivity while creating opportunities for localisation and technology integration.

SYSTEM UPGRADE

Accordingly, Thales has been expanding its aviation portfolio in India across avionics, in-flight entertainment, airport operations control centres, Digi-Yatra systems, and air traffic management solutions, with plans for drones and counter-drone technologies.

The company recently supported the induction of Air India's 787-9 aircraft equipped with Thales' AVANT Up in-flight entertainment platform, making the airline the first in the Asia-Pacific region to deploy the system. On localisation, Thales' India strategy is built around 'Make in India', 'Innovate in India' and 'Export from India', Kanagekar said.

VOC Port floats ₹517-cr berth upgrade tender

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

The VO Chidambaranar Port Authority has floated a global tender to upgrade Berth No. 7 at the VOC Port in Thoothukudi into a modern container terminal capable of handling large container vessels of up to 12,100 twenty-foot equivalent unit (TEU) capacity, with a draft of 14.20 m.

The ₹517-crore project, proposed on a design, build, finance, operate and transfer basis for a concession period of 30 years, is expected to create an annual handling capacity of 4.2 lakh TEUs. The port authority has invited global participation for the project, which is aimed at strengthening the port's container handling capability and boosting India's maritime infrastructure.

According to the tender document, the proposed up-gradation includes strengthening the existing berth with

new piles, dredging the berth pocket to a depth of minus 16.5 metres, and installing new fenders, bollards and utility infrastructure.

The project also envisages deployment of modern container handling equipment such as quay cranes, rubber-tyred gantry cranes, electric tractor trailers and reach stackers. Berth No. 7, was built in 1998 with blockwork construction. The berth has a length of 370 metres, crane rail spacing of 23.47 metres and an existing dredged depth of 11.85 metres.

JOINT VENTURE

Container operations at the berth were handled by BOT operators between December 1999 and February 2025. In 2008, the PSA International had entered into a joint venture with Sical Logistics to operate the berth for 30 years. However, PSA later exited the project following a legal dispute with the port authority over royalty payments.

Chaturvedi unveils Neopolis Brands

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Fashion retail industry veteran Shailesh Chaturvedi has launched his new venture, Neopolis Brands, which will focus on bringing and scaling up international brands in the women's fashion and accessories space in India.

The venture has raised ₹90 crore from a slew of marquee investors including Ashish Kacholia and Lashit Sanghvi of Alchemy Capital.

Strategic investors including Brandix Sri Lanka and Manipal Technologies have also come onboard the cap table.

FOREIGN BRANDS

Shailesh Chaturvedi, Founder, Neopolis Brands, told *businessline*, "we are looking at tying up with foreign brands, which are market leaders in their categories, and building their presence in India.

"We are looking at long-term partnerships with these brands. Besides India, we are also looking to tap into



Shailesh Chaturvedi, Founder, Neopolis Brands

neighbouring countries such as Sri Lanka as we have strategic investors on the cap table from such markets," he said. Chaturvedi, who stepped down as MD & CEO of Arvind Fashions in September last year, is credited with scaling up premium global fashion brands in India.

He said he had always harboured entrepreneurial ambitions and now has brought together a team of retail professionals under Neopolis.

WOMEN'S FASHION

"We have two brands in play at the moment in the women's fashion and accessor-

ies space. While we are looking to launch one this year, the second one will be launched next year," he added.

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

Quantum-safe security shifts beyond defence as spending grows

QNu Labs, the Bengaluru-based quantum cybersecurity start-up known for building quantum-safe communication and encryption solutions for defence and strategic sectors, is now seeing traction from enterprises as concerns around AI-led cyberattacks and future quantum-computing risks rise.

The company expects commercial business to contribute 60 per cent of revenues over the next two years, compared to 40 per cent from defence. QNu Labs said sectors such as BFSI, telecom and healthcare are increasingly investing in quantum-safe systems. Speaking exclusively to *businessline*, Sunil Gupta, Co-founder, CEO, QNu Labs, said enterprises are increasingly evaluating how to secure long-term data, communication networks and digital infrastructure against future threats posed by both quantum computing and autonomous AI systems.

"What has changed is that cybersecurity conversations are no longer reactive. Enterprises now see security as a business continuity and trust imperative," he said.

COMMERCIAL ROLLOUT The company believes BFSI and telecom firms will lead the commercial rollout, as they face mounting pressure to modernise systems ahead of global and Indian quantum-security migration timelines.

QNu Labs estimates the Indian enterprise quantum-security market could reach ₹500-1,000 crore over the next three to five years, driven by growing investments in quantum-safe infrastructure.

SUPPLY CHAIN The capital raised will be invested in organisational set-up, growth working capital, investments into brands, supply chain and stores, and building digital capabilities. The company will also look at "Make in India" opportunities. "There is a mismatch between addressable market and organised segment and that excites us. For instance, in the handbags segment, the total market is estimated at ₹20,000 crore with the organised segment at about ₹7,000 crore," Chaturvedi said.

Health trend sparks boom for ceramic, cast-iron cookware start-ups

Jyoti Banthia
Bengaluru

Indian households are increasingly swapping Teflon-coated pans and conventional non-stick cookware for cast iron, ceramic and toxin-free alternatives, creating a fast-growing opportunity for direct-to-consumer kitchenware start-ups and investors betting on the premiumisation of Indian kitchens.

Start-ups such as Cumin Co. and Ember Cookware are emerging as early beneficiaries of the trend, as consumers become more conscious about chemical coatings, microplastics and long-term cookware safety.

Founded in 2024, Cumin Co., which focuses on enamel cast iron cookware, has already raised \$6.52 million across two funding

rounds from Fireside Ventures and Alteria Capital. The company said it is on track to hit ₹100 crore annual recurring revenue (ARR) by the end of the year.

"People are becoming far more conscious about the materials used in everyday cookware, and that awareness is translating into meaningful purchase intent across categories like enamel cast iron," said Founders Niharika Joshi and Udit Lekhi.

FIRST-TIME BUYERS

The founders said a large share of their customers are first-time buyers of healthier cookware alternatives, typically transitioning away from traditional non-stick and aluminium cookware. They added that awareness around synthetic coatings and chemical leaching has grown sharply, particularly among younger consumers



HEALTHY LIVING. Industry executives say cookware is increasingly being viewed through the lens of health, lifestyle and design rather than pure utility

setting up modern kitchens. "The conversation has evolved from just 'what we eat' to 'how we cook', and that's a meaningful behavioural shift," Joshi and Lekhi said.

The start-up has seen strong traction for products such as Dutch ovens, *kadais* and *tawas*, while repeat purchase rates have climbed as

consumers gradually replace larger portions of their kitchens with toxin-free cookware. While metro cities remain key markets, the company said demand from tier-2 and tier-3 cities is also accelerating despite the category's premium pricing.

The shift is also drawing investor interest into what was once considered a *niche*

wellness category. Industry executives say cookware is increasingly being viewed through the lens of health, lifestyle and design rather than pure utility.

"Over the last few years, we have seen a decisive consumer shift toward healthier and more conscious living, and that mindset is now strongly influencing purchase decisions within the kitchen and cookware category as well," said Archana Jahagirdar.

INDIAN CONSUMERS

"Indian consumers today are moving beyond functional products and actively seeking toxin-free, durable and thoughtfully-designed cookware that aligns with their lifestyle aspirations," she added.

Another start-up riding the trend is Ember Cookware, founded by Siddharth

Gadodia and Himanshi Tandon.

The company recently raised \$3.2 million in funding and is targeting ₹30 crore ARR by March 2026, with plans to scale to ₹100 crore ARR by March 2027. Ember currently sells 15 products across ceramic and cast-iron cookware categories and derives nearly 50-60 per cent of its revenues from its direct-to-consumer website, with the remaining coming from marketplaces such as Amazon. About a quarter of its sales now come from tier-2 and tier-3 markets.

"A lot of our growth will come from category expansion and continuous innovation. We spend significant time in material science and product testing so that the products work harder in the kitchen and make cooking easier for consumers," said Tandon.

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SHORT TERM E-TENDER NOTICE

Tender ID: 2026_PDL_22103_1Date: 11-05-2026

E-tenders are invited from established manufacturers/suppliers for the "Supply of New 180 ml Glass bottles" through e-procurement portal (<https://pudutenders.gov.in>) only. Tender Fee of Rs.2,500/- and EMD for an amount of Rs. 4,00,000/- are to be paid through Internet Banking or NEFT/RTGS mode only. Last date and time of Submission of bids online is **22-05-2026 at 12.00 P.M.** For detailed information and Terms and Conditions please refer tenders online through e-procurement portal <https://pudutenders.gov.in>. The Tender details, and Terms and Conditions may also be downloaded from the website www.py.gov.in and <https://pdlindia.in> for reference only.

ABBU: E2/2026MANAGING DIRECTOR

**ERNAKULAM REGIONAL CO-OPERATIVE MILK PRODUCERS' UNION LTD.**
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TENDER NOTICE

No. EUP/MG/91/2026-2708.05.2026

Title	E-Tender Id	Bid closing
E-tender is invited for the transportation of milk from outside Kerala State to ERCMPU Ltd through milk tankers of 15/20/22/25/27/29/30 KL capacities on contract basis under ERCMPU Ltd. (Pre bid meeting on 18.05.2026)	2026_KCMMF_849774.1	29.05.2026 04.00 PM

For More details: Tel: 9447396859(Sd/-) Managing Director

QUICKLY.

Crude oil climbs as Hormuz stays shut



Crude oil rose after US President Donald Trump rejected Iran's response to his latest peace proposal, prolonging the effective closure of the crucial Strait of Hormuz. Brent crude futures advanced 4.6 per cent, before paring gains to trade near \$103 a barrel, while West Texas Intermediate was near \$97. In a social media post, Trump said Tehran's response was "totally unacceptable". BLOOMBERG

Gold ticks up as markets digest US-Iran updates

Gold prices reversed course to edgeup on Monday in volatile trading, as investors assessed developments in US-Iran diplomacy and awaited key US inflation data due later this week. Spot gold was up 0.3 per cent at \$4,730.49 per ounce, as of 10:20 a.m. EDT after falling over 1 per cent earlier in the session. US gold futures rose 0.2 per cent to \$4,740.40. REUTERS

Copper touches 3-month peak on supply concerns

London: Copper prices advanced to their highest in more than three months on Monday, as worries about supply shortages outweighed concerns about lower demand due to the stalemate in the West Asia war. Benchmark three-month copper on the London Metal Exchange gained 1.1 per cent to \$13,715 a tonne in official open-outcry trading, its strongest since January 29. It was on track to notch up its sixth straight session of gains. It has gained about 10 per cent so far this year, but is well below the \$14,527.50 peak hit in January. REUTERS

After PM's appeal to cut fertilizer use, Government says it has ample stocks

DEMAND BALANCE. Fertilizer sales up 25% in April; Centre pushes for the use of balanced crop nutrients

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Amid rising demand and Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal to farmers to reduce the use of chemical fertilizers by 25-50 per cent, the government on Monday said that India has ample stocks of fertilizers for the upcoming kharif sowing season. Agriculture minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan expressed confidence that it is possible to reduce 50 per cent of chemical fertilizers and still maintain productivity. The combined sales of all four key fertilizers — urea, di-ammonium phosphate (DAP), muriate of potash (MOP) and complex (combination of N, P, K nutrients) — rose 25 per cent to 23.59 lakh tonnes (lt) in April 2026, compared with 18.9 lt in the corresponding period

a year ago. While DAP sales rose by a maximum of 57 per cent to 3.45 lt, complex surged by 44 per cent to 5.15 lt. Urea sales, too, were up 14 per cent to 13.93 lt, and those of MOP by 12 per cent to 1.06 lt.

PM'S CALL On Sunday, the Prime Minister, appealed to the farmers to cut the use of chemical fertilizers by 25-50 per cent to save foreign exchange as well as soil. Reminding people that one bag of fertilizer (Urea) is sold at ₹3,000 in other countries, he said the government has taken on the burden by making it available to farmers in India at less than ₹300/bag. "We need to take a pledge...we have to do it," he said, stressing the need to curb fertilizer application as the soil is getting degraded. One day, the soil would stop producing, Modi warned and suggested that farmers

Soaring sales			
	2025-27 (April)	2026-27 (April)	% change
	(lakh tonnes)		
Urea	12.19	13.93	14.3
DAP	2.2	3.45	56.8
MoP	0.95	1.06	11.6
NPKS	3.58	5.15	43.9
Total	18.9	23.59	24.7



move towards natural farming.

PANIC BUYING In the inter-ministerial briefing on West Asia on Monday, Aparna S Sharma, Additional Secretary in the Department of Fertilizers, said that there was some panic buying initially (after the war). She also said that the Central and State governments are making efforts to

promote the balanced use of fertilizers and curb excessive use. States are taking action to curb hoarding and check the diversion of soil nutrients for commercial use. "India's fertiliser security remains comfortable and well managed," she said, adding the current stock level is more than 51 per cent of the total demand of 390.54 lt for the kharif 2026 season, which is signific-

antly higher than the usual level of 33 per cent. She further said that after the war, the domestic production was 76.78 lt while imports were 19.94 lt. The government earlier had said that domestic production for March-April was at 67.76 lt — urea 40.72 lt, DAP 5.39 lt, complex 13.65 lt. India does not produce MoP as it is 100 per cent import dependent.

SUBSIDY PRESSURE On the fertiliser subsidy bill, she said it would be cleared in due course to maintain the liquidity of fertiliser companies. She said that against a ₹2.21 lakh crore fertiliser subsidy in the last fiscal, the Budget Estimate for FY27 is ₹1.77 lakh crore. However, as global fertilizer prices have gone up, with Urea nearly doubling, the government would factor those in when the subsidy is finalised.

No plan to raise duties on gold, silver imports: Official

Amiti Sen
New Delhi



GOLD RUSH. India's gold bar imports have risen sharply from \$36.5 billion in 2022 to \$58.9 billion in 2025, per the GTRI analysis

India does not plan to increase duties on gold and silver imports despite concerns about rising import bills and dwindling foreign exchange reserves, a government official said on Monday.

On Sunday, Prime Minister Narendra Modi asked people to avoid buying gold for a year to help the country save foreign currency as it tries to deal with the effects of the prolonged US-Israel war with Iran.

TAX JITTERS The PM's statement resul-

ted in speculations that the government may increase the import duties on gold and silver to discourage its

imports now that elections in key States, including West Bengal and Tamil Nadu, are over.

CURRENT DUTY But government officials tracking the matter denied that there were any plans of raising import duties on either gold or silver. Currently, import of gold in all forms attracts a 6 per cent duty, including 5 per cent basic customs duty (BCD) and 1 per cent agriculture infrastructure and development cess (AIDC).

On silver, there is a total import duty of 6 per cent for eligible Indian residents. The Indian PM's appeals to avoid gold purchases for a year in the national interest must be supported as imports are hurting India's foreign exchange reserves and trade balance, accord-

ing to Ajay Srivastava from GTRI.

FTA IMPACT However, the government must review its Free Trade Agreement (FTA) policies, especially tariff concessions on precious metals offered to Dubai under the India-UAE trade deal, a GTRI analysis noted.

The FTA has significantly contributed to the recent surge in gold imports, it said.

BULLION BOOM India's gold bar imports have risen sharply from \$36.5 billion in 2022 to \$58.9 billion in 2025, per the analysis.

Centre aims to integrate farming with health, launches SEHAT mission

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi



Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan ANI

Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan and Health Minister JP Nadda on Monday jointly launched a national mission, Science Excellence for Health Through Agricultural Transformation, acronymed as SEHAT (or health), that aimed at building an integrated farming system to improve human health with a focus on traditional knowledge.

The mission will not have any separate funding as both the implementing agencies — Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR) and Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) — will jointly bear the expenses. But Chouhan said that funding would not be a constraint to achieving the goal.

Addressing the gathering, Chouhan also stressed the rich value of Indian traditional knowledge and recited

some Sanskrit verses that talked about the selection of food to remain healthy.

PROMOTE BIOFORTIFIED CROPS He said the SEHAT mission would promote biofortified crops, healthy livestock and nutrient-rich fish products, encourage diverse, safe and balanced diets across age groups, and reduce occupational risks for agricultural workers. The mission will also develop food-based solutions to address malnu-

trition, obesity, diabetes, hypertension and micronutrient deficiencies, he said and advised both research bodies to have a target-based approach rather than an unending long-term plan.

"The country has sufficient foodgrains now. The focus is on ensuring nutritious food for the people and boosting their health," Chouhan said.

ICAR Director General M L Jat said the institute had developed and released 203 biofortified crop varieties over the last ten years, but the absence of clinical trials had limited public appreciation of these advances. With ICMR's involvement, it would create a win-win situation by validating and promoting such varieties, Jat added. ICMR Director General Rajiv Bahl noted that agriculture and health solutions had long operated in isolation, limiting the translation of agricultural progress into measurable health outcomes.

Go long in natural gas after it breaks out of ₹275

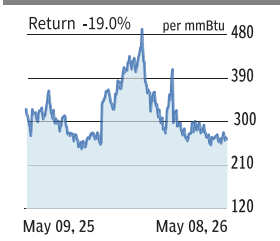
Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

Natural gas futures have been charting a sideways trend for over a month. The May futures have largely been trading between ₹250 and ₹275. Before that, the contract saw a decline.

COMMODITY CALL.

That said, the price action since early April shows that the bears are showing signs of weakness. In fact, the chart has started showing signals that natural gas futures are forming an inverted head and shoulder. However, for the pattern to confirm, the contract has to break out of ₹275.

In case natural gas futures break out of ₹275, the outlook can turn positive. The confirmation of the pattern will open the door for a rally to ₹300. A breakout of ₹300 will add momentum to the upside, potentially rising to ₹320. However, if the contract falls off the res-



istance at ₹275, it can drop to ₹250. A breach of this can extend the downtrend to ₹230 and ₹200, notable support levels.

Overall, as it stands, natural gas futures will have a bearish inclination, though with lesser strength now. But the breakout of ₹275 will overturn the trend.

TRADE STRATEGY Hold on to the natural gas futures we suggested at ₹265. Target and stop-loss can be ₹235 and ₹280. If the contract hits the above stop-loss, it will indicate the confirmation of an inverted head and shoulder pattern. In this case, one can go long with a stop-loss at ₹260 for a target of ₹320.

SEA endorses PM's views on edible oil usage

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

Following the appeal by Prime Minister Narendra Modi to reduce the use of edible oils, the Solvent Extractors' Association of India (SEA) has said that it is better to make modest sacrifices today than confront bigger challenges later.

BV Mehta, Executive Director, SEA, said Narendra Modi's appeal on controlling edible oil consumption carries far greater economic and strategic significance.

"With climate uncertainties rising, biodiesel mandates tightening global vegetable oil supplies, and geopolitical tensions adding fresh risks, this is perhaps

the right moment for the nation to think long term. Along with boosting domestic oilseed production, balanced consumption habits will play a crucial role in reducing vulnerability," he said.

WEST ASIA CONFLICT West Asia conflict have already impacted freight, energy prices, currency movements, and overall commodity sentiment. All of this eventually influence edible oil prices and import costs. "At a time when global weather risks like El Nino threaten agricultural production and international edible oil prices remain vulnerable, India cannot afford rising import dependence," he added.

Amid W. Asia crisis, edible oil sector seeks govt help

Our Bureau
Mangaluru



TRADE PRESSURE. The landed cost of palm oil has jumped by more than \$105 a tonne, and that of soybean oil by \$80 a tonne, after the start of West Asia war, according to SEA

war) to \$1,235 on May 7 (post-ceasefire).

The C&F (Mumbai) price of crude palm oil (CPO) increased by \$105 a tonne from \$1,150 on February 27 to \$1,255 a tonne on May 7.

The C&F (Mumbai) price of soybean oil increased by \$80 a tonne from \$1,230 a tonne on February 27 to \$1,310 on May 7.

STABILISED FLOWS Sanjeev Asthana, President of SEA, said that while the ceasefire has brought some stability to trade flows, prices across most oils remain elevated compared to pre-war levels.

As fossil fuels become costlier, many countries have increased biodiesel blending mandates to cushion

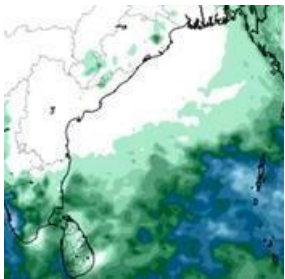
the impact domestically. Indonesia has announced 50 per cent blending as of July 1, and Malaysia has increased blending to 15 per cent from 10 per cent. All these measures, coupled with higher ocean freight costs, have significantly increased the landed cost of imported edible oils in India, he said.

'NO RESPITE' Stating that the ceasefire has had only a limited impact on edible oil prices, he said structural challenges such as high freight costs, elevated insurance premiums, and tight global supply persist.

"For India, this translates into higher import bills, increased working capital requirements, and sustained pressure on domestic prices, with no immediate respite visible in the near term.

Myanmar sees normal monsoon onset; Bay turns active

Vinson Kurian
Thiruvananthapuram



The first organised pulses of the 2026 south-west monsoon seem to be taking shape, with Myanmar pencilling in a near-normal onset even as twin low-pressure systems threaten to stir the Bay of Bengal into early-season action.

The monsoon may set in over southern Myanmar between May 13 and May 17, almost in line with the climatological date of May 18, before steadily advancing into the country's deltaic regions between May 18 and May 22, according to the latest outlook issued by the Myanmar Department of Meteorology and Hydrology. The agency also hinted at an increasingly energetic Bay of Bengal during the next fortnight, beginning Monday, with two low-pressure areas expected to form over the basin, one of them possibly intensifying into a depression. Such a sequence, it said, would support a moderate-strength monsoon during the period.

FIRST 'LOW' FORMS

Closer home, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) on Monday confirmed the formation of a low-pressure area over the south-west Bay off the north Sri Lanka coast, and placed it under watch for further intensification during the next two days.

Under normal May conditions, prevailing monsoonal flows tend to steer such systems east-north-eastwards, away from Sri Lanka and Tamil Nadu coasts and into the central Bay towards Myanmar and Bangladesh.

But the atmosphere may not yield so easily this time. Numerical weather models are yet to converge on the exact movement and evolution of the nascent system, reflecting the complexity typical of

Myanmar's met agency hinted at a more energetic Bay over the next fortnight from Monday www.tropicaltidbits.com

the pre-monsoon transition phase. Complicating matters further is a supportive circulation in place over the south-east Arabian Sea and adjoining Lakshadweep off the Kerala coast.

The IMD has identified a cyclonic circulation there, linked to an elongated trough extending across coastal and south interior Karnataka into north interior Karnataka.

SEASONAL SIGNALS

Meteorologists believe the interaction between the Bay system and the Arabian Sea circulation could prove decisive in determining whether the 'low' escapes into the central Bay or remain tethered closer to the southern peninsula for longer than usual. Any sustained organisation of low-pressure systems over the Bay at this stage is regarded as an encouraging precursor to seasonal rains, though forecasters caution that the atmosphere is still in its formative phase and prone to abrupt shifts.

Even as the Bay begins to stir, widespread thunderstorms and heavy rain are entrenching themselves across large parts of the peninsula and North-West India, signalling an increasingly volatile transition into the monsoon. The IMD has warned that more intense spells are likely over the southern peninsula during the coming week.



Though India produces around 60 lakh tonnes of cashew apple every year, a major chunk of it is wasted

'Stop wastage of cashew apples, explore their value-addition potential'

AJ Vinayak
Mangaluru

Indians should make efforts to stop wastage of cashew apples and explore their potential for producing value-added products, according to Shree Padre, who has been working to popularise the value-added possibilities of cashew apples.

Speaking on the sidelines of a cashew apple festival in Mangaluru on Friday, Padre said India has remained far behind in exploring the potential of value-added products from cashew apple nearly eight decades after Independence.

Citing the example of Brazil, he said farmers there earn revenue from cashew apples also, as nearly 25 per cent of cashew apples is used for the preparation of value-added products.

Cashew apple pomace is used in the preparation of vegan meat in Brazil. India has many things to learn from

Brazil on cashew apple value-addition, he said. Though India produces around 60 lakh tonnes of cashew apple every year, a major chunk of it is wasted. In Goa, it is used for the preparation of an alcoholic beverage.

USE IN AYURVEDA

Urging the need to explore the potential of non-alcoholic juice from cashew apples, he said zero-additive cashew apple juice can be prepared by removing tannin from the fruit. Cashew apple

juice is rich in vitamin C and contains anti-oxidants.

Giving an example of an enterprise from Maharashtra, he said cashew apple is used in the preparation of some Ayurvedic medicines.

Though the government organisations such as Kerala Agricultural University and Directorate of Cashew Research have come out with more than 50 value-added products from cashew apple, more efforts will have to be made to popularise them.

A farmer couple from Kasaragod district of Kerala have begun the preparation of cashew apple pulp for the domestic market.

Padre, who is also the Editor of farm journal 'Adike Patrike', said he gets a common answer from most of the scientists that cashew apple is a perishable produce. 'Neera' was once considered as a perishable product. However, carton packaging has helped improve its shelf life and reach wider section of consumers.

Retain import duty on natural rubber at current level: Upasi

V Sajeew Kumar
Kochi

The United Planters' Association of Southern India (UPASI) has urged the Centre not to alter the existing import duty structure of natural rubber, as it affects the livelihood of nearly 13.2 lakh growers who depend on the sector.

Ajoy Thipaiah, UPASI president, emphasised the need to maintain the status quo on import duty on NR in the context of demands from sections of the user industry seeking reduction in import duty on key inputs and raw materials. He pointed out that domestic natural rubber prices have shown a modest upward trend in recent months due to geopolitical

developments and production shortages both globally and domestically arising from seasonal agro-climatic conditions. However, Indian NR prices remained subdued in comparison with international prices over the last two years, with domestic prices trailing international prices in 16 months out of the past 24 months. In addition, any marginal improvement in price realisation has been significantly offset by the steep rise in input costs.

Santosh Kumar, Chairman, Rubber Committee, said that imports of both NR and Compound Rubber (CR) have increased considerably over the years. Of particular concern is the growing share of compound rubber imports, which now account for nearly 40 per cent of total rubber imports.

QUICKLY.

Embraer, Bharat Forge sign materials supply pact



New Delhi: Embraer and Bharat Forge Limited on Monday announced the signing of a contract for the supply of forged raw materials for aerospace manufacturing consumption. The Brazil-based global aerospace company's recent initiatives are centred around pitching its C-390 transporters for the Indian Air Force's requirement of 60 medium transport aircrafts. On February 20, Embraer had signed an MoU with Hindalco Industries Limited to identify possibilities of sourcing aerospace grade aluminum raw material to support the Brazilian company's industrial initiatives. It has also tied up with Mahindra Group to establish a C-390 Millennium Maintenance, Repair, and Overhaul (MRO) facility in India, provided it gets MTA contract. **OUR BUREAU**

Akasa Air to start Noida airport flights from Jun 16

New Delhi: Akasa Air will start flights from the Noida International Airport from June 16, the second airline set to commence services from the new airport. The airport, which was inaugurated on March 28, will start commercial operations from June 15. In a release on Monday, Akasa Air said it would start daily flights connecting Noida airport with Bengaluru and Navi Mumbai from June 16. Further, Akasa Air would have an MRO (Maintenance, Repair and Overhaul) facility within the airport premises. IndiGo will be the first carrier to start operations from the airport from June 15. **PT**

'Noida airport charges based on greenfield airport economics'

SCALE MISMATCH. Jewar facility can't be compared with its Delhi counterpart having huge traffic volumes: AERA

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

The Airports Economic Regulatory Authority (AERA) has clarified that the tariff structure for the upcoming Noida International Airport has been determined on the basis of the proposal submitted by the airport developer as well as the economics of operating a greenfield airport with high upfront investments and low initial passenger traffic. The clarification comes amid concerns raised by airlines and industry executives after fares from the upcoming airport were found to be nearly identical to those from Indira Gandhi International Airport despite Uttar Pradesh offering significantly lower aviation turbine fuel (ATF) taxation.

AIRPORT COMPARISONS Speaking to *businessline*, AERA Chairperson SKG Rahate said comparisons between Delhi airport and Noida International Airport from an airport charges perspective are misplaced given the structural differences between the two airports. "Comparison of user development fee (UDF) and aeronautical charges between Delhi airport and Noida airport is misplaced from airport economics point of view, as Delhi is a brownfield, depreciated asset with high passenger traffic whereas Jewar is a newly-opened greenfield airport with new assets built by putting large investments upfront and with initial low passenger traffic volume," Rahate said. According to AERA, the tariff structure for the airport was worked out on the basis of investments made



PRICING FRAMEWORK. AERA said it undertook a comprehensive tariff determination exercise based on the 'multi-year tariff proposal' submitted by the airport operator

for constructing the airport and the admissible returns under airport tariff guidelines to ensure viable operations.

COLLECTIVE DECISION AERA further said it undertook a comprehensive tariff determination exercise based on the 'multi-year tariff proposal' submitted by the airport operator and held stakeholder consultations involving airlines, passenger associations, industry bodies and other airport operators. Following regulatory scrutiny and prudence checks, AERA said it significantly rationalised the 'aggregate revenue requirement' proposed by the airport operator. Notably, against the airport operator's proposal of around ₹6,800 crore for the 1st control period (5 year tariff cycle), AERA said it has allowed around ₹5,300 crore after moderating various cost elements. Furthermore, the regu-

lator said a sizeable portion of the airport's revenue recovery has been deferred to the next tariff cycle in order to moderate tariff burden during the initial years of operations.

DEFERRED TARIFFS As a result, AERA fixed the UDF for departing domestic passengers at ₹490 against the ₹653 proposed by the airport operator. Similarly, the domestic landing charge was fixed at ₹725 per tonne compared to the proposed ₹760 per tonne by the airport operator. "The UDF allowed by AERA is comparable with the national average of UDF at major airports and is also well within the range of UDF currently levied at non-major airports," the regulator said. Presently, air fares from Noida International Airport and Delhi airport are nearly identical on several announced domestic routes

despite Uttar Pradesh levying only 1 per cent value added tax (VAT) on ATF compared to nearly 25 per cent in Delhi.

LISTED FARES A *businessline* check of fares available on online travel agency Ixigo showed no meaningful difference between fares from the two airports on announced routes. The fares on the Jewar-Lucknow and Delhi-Lucknow sectors were identical at ₹3,394, while Jewar-Hyderabad and Delhi-Hyderabad flights were both priced at ₹6,129. Similarly, fares to Amritsar from both airports were also identical. The lower fuel tax structure in Uttar Pradesh was expected to provide airlines operating from Noida International Airport with a cost advantage over Delhi airport operations. However, airline execut-

ives told *businessline* that higher aeronautical charges and UDF at the airport are offsetting gains arising from lower fuel taxation.

PASSENGER IMPACT Nonetheless, industry insiders aware of the tariff structure said these charges account for only around 6 per cent of the overall operating cost, whereas airlines are deriving significant benefits from the lower VAT on ATF. Meanwhile, IndiGo, which has commenced bookings from the airport ahead of commercial operations beginning June 15, had also raised concerns over the tariff structure during stakeholder consultations with the regulator.

In its submissions to AERA, the airline said landing charges for narrow-body aircraft at the airport are significantly higher compared to Delhi airport for domestic operations. Industry executives also said the elevated airport charges may affect the airport's ability to attract passengers during the initial phase of operations, particularly given Delhi airport's stronger connectivity, metro access, and established network presence. Nevertheless, AERA maintained that airport charges at Jewar and Delhi cannot be kept at par due to differences in investment structure, traffic profile, and airport maturity. On its part, airport operator Yamuna International Airport Private Limited has maintained that the tariff structure is aligned with comparable greenfield airports and necessary for long-term infrastructure recovery of a new greenfield airport to ensure it's viable operation.

Indian nationals on hantavirus-hit ship evacuated, says govt

PT Jyothi Datta
Mumbai

Two Indian crew members on the MV *Hondius* have been evacuated to the Netherlands, where they will be quarantined, said a note from the Indian embassy in Madrid, on the hantavirus-hit cruise ship.

The ship carrying 150 people including the two Indian members anchored off the coast of Spain's Canary Island on Sunday, following protocols from the World Health Organization (WHO) and the Spanish authorities, the note said, adding that the Indian members were "healthy and asymptomatic". As the ship headed to Tenerife (Canary Island), following the hantavirus outbreak, for passengers to embark — WHO's director-general Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus addressed residents of the island and said, "this is not another Covid. The current public health risk from hantavirus remains low." On the repeated mention of an 'outbreak', he said, "memories surface that none of us have fully put to rest. The pain of 2020 is still real, and I do not dismiss it for a single moment."

Hantaviruses are a group of viruses carried by rodents that can cause severe disease in humans, the WHO said. People usually get infected through contact with infected rodents or their urine, droppings or saliva. "Right now, there are no symptomatic passengers on



board. A WHO expert is on that ship. Medical supplies are in place. Spain's authorities have prepared a careful, step-by-step plan: passengers will be ferried ashore at the industrial port of Granadilla, far from residential areas, in sealed, guarded vehicles, through a completely cordoned-off corridor, and repatriated directly to their home countries. You will not encounter them. Your families will not encounter them," he added.

SPAIN'S HELP The WHO's request to Spain was not made arbitrarily, the DG said, adding it was made in accordance with the International Health Regulations — the legally-binding framework that defines the rights and obligations of countries and the WHO when responding to public health events of international concern. "Under those rules, the nearest port with sufficient medical capacity must be identified to ensure the safety and dignity of those on board. Tenerife met that standard. Spain honoured it," he added. "Nearly 150 people from 23 countries have been at sea for weeks, some of them grieving, all of them frightened, all of them longing for home. Tenerife has been chosen because it has the medical capacity, the infrastructure, and the humanity to help them reach safety," the DG said.

Ease visa restrictions, attract more foreign tourists, travel sector body urges govt

Our Bureau
Mumbai

An association representing travel companies and hotels has renewed the demand for simplification of visa norms and increased promotions to attract foreign tourists into India. Federation of Associations in Indian Tourism and Hospitality (FAITH) has made this suggestion in



the backdrop of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's call to Indians to reduce over-

seas travel. While the association has welcomed the Prime Minister's sentiment to conserve foreign exchange, it has emphasised on the need to attract more foreign tourists. **POLICY SUPPORT** "This requires easing visa restrictions, improving connectivity and significantly strengthening India's tourism promotion abroad," said FAITH general secret-

ary Rajiv Mehra. "It is unfortunate that a country blessed with immense natural beauty, cultural richness, spirituality and world-class historical monuments attracts only around two crore foreign tourists annually. India has the potential to emerge as one of the world's leading tourism destinations if the right policy support and global marketing efforts are undertaken," he added.

Alcobev-makers get high on soju thanks to K-culture booming among Gen Z

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

The growing popularity of Korean entertainment has helped familiarise Indian consumers with alcoholic beverage soju. Over the past few years, audiences have become increasingly exposed to Korean dining and drinking experiences through streaming platforms, restaurants and social media. Raghav Sachdeva, Co-founder and CEO, Nuvola Spirits, says that Korean culture has become increasingly mainstream among GenZ and young millennials. "Soju became aspirational through culture before it was commercially available at scale. India's drinking culture is evolving. Consumers are more experimental, globally aware, and open to lighter, more social drinking formats beyond traditional spirits. There is also a visible shift towards experience-driven consumption, where people are buying into culture, rituals, and lifestyle alongside the product," he says. Banking on this demand, Nuvola Spirits launched Seoulmate Soju in Karnataka

in April. The beverage is made from premium rice distillate. Since then, the company has expanded to Goa and Delhi and is preparing to enter Haryana, Maharashtra and Assam. Bengaluru has emerged an important market given its younger, affluent and globally exposed consumer base. "The larger vision is to establish Seoulmate as a nationally-recognised soju brand by scaling across culturally relevant and consumption-forward markets," Sachdeva noted. **KOREAN PARTNERSHIP** Similarly, Monika Alcobev Limited, an importer of premium wines and spirits, partnered with the South Korea-based Jinro, one of the country's most popular soju labels. In 2024 alone, it sold 96.8 million cases worldwide. Today, the brand reaches more than 80 countries. Launched in December 2025, Monika Alcobev handles import, distribution, and marketing across major cities for Jinro. Jinro's rollout in India has commenced across Delhi, Haryana, Chandigarh, Uttar Pradesh, Mumbai,



Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Goa. The company plans to strengthen its presence across additional tier-I and tier-II cities, supported by Monika Alcobev's distribution network spanning hospitality, retail, and travel retail channels. "Indian consumers, particularly younger audiences, are increasingly experimenting with approachable and easy-drinking beverage formats. Flavoured soju fits naturally within these consumption patterns," says Kunal Patel, MD, Monika Alcobev. Jinro's India portfolio includes Chamisl Fresh alongside variants such as Green Grape, Plum, Strawberry and Peach. Penguin Overseas, an importer and distributor of

premium spirits, launched 'So Good' Soju in India in April. The beverage has been developed and manufactured in India. **PAN-ASIAN APPEAL** Currently, the brand's still range has peach and green apple variants, while the sparkling portfolio includes variants like Yuzu Lime and K-Bomb. Flavours such as green grape, strawberry, blueberry and lemon, are expected to follow. "Currently, we have launched in Maharashtra and Haryana and will be launching in Karnataka, Goa, Delhi, Arunachal Pradesh, and Mizoram," says Jaspreet Singh, Founder and CEO, Penguin Overseas. Soju can be a substitute for vodka, beer, and whisky since it pairs well with pan-Asian cuisine, which has gained momentum in India over the past few years., he says. While India remains a whisky-first market, soju can create its own distinct space within the broader alcobev ecosystem, particularly among younger consumers, the players echoed.

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